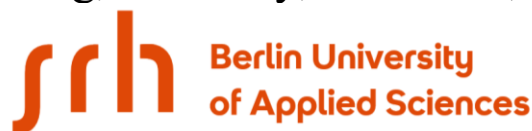


Multi-Sector Consulting: Analytics-Driven Approaches to Digital Transformation Strategy

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PRELIMINARY PAGES

Abstract

List of Figures

List of Tables

List of Abbreviations

1. INTRODUCTION	1
1.1 Background and Context.....	1
1.2 The Analytics–Execution Gap	2
1.3 Problem Statement	3
1.4 Research Gap	3
1.5 Consulting-Led Digital Transformation	4
1.6 Research Aim and Objectives	5
1.7 Research Questions	6
1.7.1 Central Research Question.....	6
1.7.2 Sub-Research Questions	6
1.8 Overview of Theoretical Positioning.....	7
1.9 Contribution of the Study.....	8
1.10 Structure of the Thesis	9
2. LITERATURE REVIEW	10
2.1 Digital Business Strategy and Analytics Foundations	10
2.1.1 Digital Strategy in Complex Organizations	10
2.1.2 Analytics as Strategic Capability	11
2.1.3 From Insight Generation to Organizational Impact	12
2.2 Strategy Execution and Operational Alignment	13
2.2.1 Strategy-to-Operations Translation.....	13
2.2.2 Governance Structures and Performance Systems	14
2.2.3 Execution Drift and Breakdown Patterns	15
2.3 Organizational Constraints in Digital Transformation	16
2.3.1 Structural Governance Constraints	16
2.3.2 Cultural and Cognitive Constraints.....	17
2.3.3 Political and Power Dynamics	18
2.3.4 Resource-Based Constraints	19
2.4 Analytical Lenses for Understanding Execution Under Constraint.....	20
2.5 Contextual Industry Exemplars.....	21

2.5.1 AI Industrialization in Banking — DBS Bank	21
2.5.2 AI-Driven Process Reengineering in Insurance — If P&C	22
2.5.3 High-Profile Digital Transformation Failure — GE Digital/Predix	23
2.6 Theoretical Synthesis and Research Proposition	24
2.6.1 The Missing Translation Mechanism.....	24
2.6.2 Limits of Canonical Execution Frameworks	25
2.6.3 Positioning of the Present Study	26
3. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK	27
3.1 Scope Refinement and Conceptual Delimitation	27
3.2 Overview of the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model.....	28
3.2.1 Core Analytical Logic.....	28
3.2.2 Layered Structure–Agency Relationship	29
3.3 Definition of Core Constructs	30
3.3.1 Analytics Capability.....	30
3.3.2 Consultant-Led Translation Mechanisms	30
3.3.2.1 Interpretation and Framing	31
3.3.2.2 Governance Filtering.....	31
3.3.2.3 Political Negotiation.....	32
3.3.2.4 Narrative Construction.....	32
3.3.3 Organizational Constraint Typology.....	32
3.3.4 Strategic Execution Decisions	33
3.4 SRQ–Construct Mapping.....	34
3.5 Visual Representation	36
3.6 Analytical Orientation for Empirical Inquiry	39
4. METHODOLOGY	40
4.1 Research Philosophy and Approach	40
4.1.1 Critical Realist Ontology	40
4.1.2 Interpretivist Epistemology.....	42
4.2 Research Scope and Analytical Delimitation	43
4.3 Research Context: Multi-Sector Consulting	44
4.4 Sampling Strategy and Participant Profile.....	45
4.5 Data Collection	47
4.5.1 Interview Design.....	47
4.5.2 Ethical Considerations	48

4.6 Data Analysis Strategy.....	48
4.6.1 Deductive Coding Framework.....	48
4.6.2 Coding Stages: From First-Order Concepts to Aggregate Dimensions.....	49
4.6.3 Cross-Interview Pattern Validation and Constraint Pre-Classification	50
4.6.4 Mechanism Reconstruction.....	50
4.6.5 Refined Translation Mediation Framework.....	50
4.7 Trustworthiness and Rigor.....	51
5. EMPIRICAL FINDINGS	52
5.1 Analytical Strategy and Mechanism Identification.....	52
5.2 Consultant Interpretation and Framing of Analytics Insights.....	58
5.2.1 From Data to Strategic Narrative: The Interpretive Function.....	59
5.2.2 Audience Calibration and Staged Communication.....	60
5.2.3 Operationalization: From Approved Insight to Execution Action.....	61
5.2.4 The Four-Stage Translation Sequence	62
5.3 Organizational Constraint Configurations	63
5.3.1 Structural and Governance Constraints	63
5.3.2 Resource and Capability Constraints.....	65
5.3.3 Accountability and Incentive Constraints.....	66
5.3.4 Cultural Constraints and Sector Variation	67
5.4 Governance Dynamics: Centralization vs. Decentralization	68
5.4.1 The Dominant Pattern: Hybrid Architecture.....	68
5.4.2 Centralization: Standardization at the Cost of Speed	69
5.4.3 Decentralization: Speed at the Cost of Alignment.....	69
5.4.4 Governance Configuration and Sector-Specific Constraints	70
5.4.5 Governance Configuration and Decision Authority	70
5.5 Political and Cognitive Mediation Processes.....	71
5.5.1 Leadership Cognitive Framing of Analytics.....	71
5.5.2 Informal Power Structures and Relational Networks	73
5.5.3 Cultural Assumptions and Selective Adoption	74
5.5.4 Trust, Alert Fatigue, and Behavioral Adoption	75
5.6 Cross-Theme Mechanisms and Execution Breakdown Dynamics	76
5.6.1 Recurring Mechanism Sequences	76
5.6.2 Points of Execution Drift	78
5.6.3 Emergent Tensions.....	78

6. DISCUSSION	79
6.1 Revisiting the Research Questions.....	79
6.2 Structural and Governance Reinterpretation.....	80
6.2.1 Governance as Sequential Filtering, Not Parallel Processing.....	80
6.2.2 The Hybrid Governance Convergence.....	81
6.2.3 Structural Constraint Configurations and Execution Failure.....	81
6.3 Cultural and Cognitive Mediation	82
6.3.1 The Analytics–Culture Gap as a Structural Condition	82
6.3.2 Leadership Cognitive Frames as Mediating Conditions.....	82
6.3.3 Alert Fatigue and the Behavioral Adoption Gap	83
6.4 Political Filtering and Power Dynamics	83
6.4.1 The Power School Revisited in Analytics Contexts	83
6.4.2 Informal Networks as Translation Accelerators and Blockers	84
6.4.3 Budget Cycles as Political Structures	85
6.5 Refined Analytics-to-Execution Framework	85
6.6 Theoretical Contributions	87
6.6.1 The Translation Mechanism as Primary Unit of Analysis.....	87
6.6.2 The Consulting Professional as Translation Agent.....	88
6.6.3 Execution Drift as Theoretical Construct	88
6.6.4 The Recursive Dependency Problem.....	89
7. IMPLICATIONS	90
7.1 Theoretical Implications	90
7.1.1 The Translation Mechanism as Integrating Theoretical Construct.....	91
7.1.2 The Recursive Dependency Problem as Novel Theoretical Contribution	92
7.1.3 Execution Drift as Analytically Productive Construct.....	93
7.1.4 The Consulting Professional as Undertheorized Translation Agent.....	94
7.2 Managerial Implications	95
7.2.1 Governance Architecture as a Strategic Design Decision	95
7.2.2 Addressing the Analytics–Execution Gap Through Accountability Structures	95
7.2.3 Managing the Budget-Lock-Drift Sequence.....	96
7.2.4 Building Analytics-Receptive Leadership Culture	97
7.3 Implications for Consulting Practice	98
7.3.1 Translation Competence as a Distinct Professional Capability	98
7.3.2 Pre-Governance Coalition-Building as Standard Engagement Practice	98

7.3.3 Framing Strategy as an Engagement Design Imperative	99
7.3.4 Operationalizing the Four-Stage Translation Sequence	99
8. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH.....	100
8.1 Methodological Limitations.....	100
8.1.1 Single-Perspective Dataset: The Absence of Organizational Counterparts.....	100
8.1.2 Sample Size and Analytical Saturation.....	101
8.1.3 Retrospective Self-Report Data and Recall Bias	102
8.1.4 Analytical Generalization and Transferability Boundaries.....	103
8.2 Scope Limitations	103
8.2.1 Exclusive Focus on the Consultant's Position in the Translation Process	103
8.2.2 Absence of Client Organizational Data	104
8.2.3 Temporal Limitation: Rapidly Evolving AI Landscape	105
8.3 Future Research Directions	106
8.3.1 Multi-Perspective and Longitudinal Designs.....	108
8.3.2 Statistical Validation at Scale	109
8.3.3 The Generative AI Translation Frontier	109
9. CONCLUSION.....	110
9.1 Summary of Findings.....	110
9.2 Answer to the Central Research Question	112
9.3 Final Reflections	113
Appendix A: Interview Questionnaire	116
Appendix B: Participant Profile Summary	119
Appendix C: Ethical Compliance Statement	121
Appendix D: Coding Framework — Deductive Code Families and Sub-Codes.....	122
Appendix E: Stage 2 — Master Coding Matrix.....	124
Appendix F: Stage 3 — Axial Coding: Second-Order Theme Matrix	133
Appendix G: Stage 4 — Selective Coding: Aggregate Dimension Matrix	137
Appendix H: Gioia Data Structure: Summary by Aggregate Dimension.....	143
Appendix I: Stage 5 — Cross-Interview Pattern Analysis	144
Appendix J: Stage 6 — Mechanism Reconstruction	146
Appendix K: Stage 7 — Translation Mediation Framework.....	148
References.....	151
Appendix L: SRH Official Affidavit and AI Usage Declaration.....	152
LIST OF GENERATIVE AI TOOL USAGES	152

AFFIDAVIT-1 153

 Legal Caution..... 154

AFFIDAVIT-2 155

Appendix M: Participant Information Sheet..... 156

Abstract

This study investigates how consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints. It develops and empirically reconstructs the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model: a seven-stage mechanism through which analytical outputs are mediated, modified, and operationalized within client organizations.

Grounded in a critical realist ontology and an interpretivist epistemology, the study employs an exploratory qualitative design. Eight semi-structured interviews were conducted with consulting professionals across life sciences, technology, energy, financial services, and product development sectors. Data analysis followed a hybrid abductive approach, producing a Gioia data structure of ninety-seven first-order concepts organized into six aggregate dimensions.

The empirical findings address four Sub-Research Questions. With respect to consultant interpretation and framing (SRQ 1), the study identifies four translation mechanisms: framing as a strategic opportunity, staged audience-calibrated communication, revenue-linked operationalization prioritization, and a practitioner-validated (interpret–decide–execute–measure) sequence. With respect to organizational constraints (SRQ 2), the study documents four interacting constraint categories, which are structural and governance, resource and capability, accountability, incentive, and cultural, that combine to produce patterned execution failure sequences, most pervasively the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence. With respect to governance architecture (SRQ 3), the study finds that hybrid hub-and-spoke governance models dominate both observed organizational configurations and preferred practitioner recommendations, with governance structure conditioning not only execution speed but the institutional authority of

analytical recommendations. With respect to political and cognitive mediation (SRQ 4), the study identifies leadership cognitive framing, informal power network dynamics, cultural selective adoption, and alert fatigue as the primary micro-level processes through which analytics-driven recommendations are accepted, adapted, or suppressed.

Four theoretical contributions are advanced: the Translation Model as an integrating mechanism-centered framework; the consulting professional theorized as a distinctive translation agent; execution drift reconceptualized as a constitutive rather than anomalous feature of effective translation; and the recursive dependency problem — the condition in which the enablers required for effective translation are precisely the conditions that analytics-driven transformation is designed to produce.

List of Figures

Note. This thesis contains no standalone figures. All data displays and analytical matrices are presented as tables (see List of Tables). The Gioia Data Structure is presented as Table 5.1 in Chapter 5.

List of Tables

Table 3.1 SRQ–Construct Mapping and Analytical Alignment — mapping of Sub-Research Questions to core constructs, canonical theoretical anchors, and interview operationalization strategies.

Table 3.2 Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mediation Framework — seven-stage process representation.

Table 4.1 Participant Profile and SRQ Relevance — professional role, sector, seniority level, and primary SRQ relevance for all eight interview participants (INT-01 through INT-08).

Table 5.1 Gioia Data Structure — Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism — three-level analytical structure comprising ninety-seven first-order concepts, second-order themes, and six aggregate dimensions.

Table 7.1 Summary of Theoretical Implications — four theoretical implications mapped to source construct, theoretical significance, and future research direction.

Table 8.1 Future Research Agenda for Analytics-to-Execution Translation Studies — seven research directions mapped to limitations addressed, recommended design, and key constructs.

List of Abbreviations

AI	Artificial Intelligence
APA	American Psychological Association
CDAO	Chief Data and Analytics Officer
CRQ	Central Research Question
DELTA	Data, Enterprise, Leadership, Targets, Analysts (Davenport & Harris, 2017)
DT	Digital Transformation
FMCG	Fast-Moving Consumer Goods
GDPR	General Data Protection Regulation
INT-01 through INT-08	Interview participant identifiers
IoT	Internet of Things
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
ML	Machine Learning
OSM	Office of Strategy Management (Kaplan & Norton, 2008)
POC	Proof of Concept
ROI	Return on Investment
SaaS	Software as a Service
SRQ	Sub-Research Question
STRATEX	Strategic Expenditure (Kaplan & Norton, 2008)

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background and Context

The opening decades of the twenty-first century have been defined by an accelerating integration of digital technologies into the strategic and operational dimensions of organizational life. Data analytics, artificial intelligence, and machine learning have progressively migrated from specialized technical domains to central instruments of organizational strategy, reshaping how institutions generate knowledge, allocate resources, and pursue competitive differentiation (Rogers, 2016; Evans, 2017). The proliferation of cloud-based infrastructure, enterprise data platforms, and real-time performance monitoring systems has dramatically expanded the volume, velocity, and accessibility of organizational data, enabling the generation of analytical insights at a scale and speed previously unavailable to managerial decision makers.

Within this landscape, digital transformation has emerged as a defining organizational imperative. Across sectors, organizations have pursued large-scale transformation initiatives aimed at embedding digital technologies into core operational processes, reconfiguring business models, and repositioning competitive strategy for a data-rich environment (Rogers, 2016; Pehrsson, 2023). These initiatives have been accompanied by substantial investment in analytics capabilities, as organizations recognize that competitive advantage increasingly derives not from access to technology alone but from the organizational capacity to generate, interpret, and act on the analytical insights that technology produces.

Despite this investment, organizations consistently encounter a persistent and consequential gap between the generation of analytical insights and their realization as execution-level strategic decisions. Analytics and AI capabilities generate outputs that are technically sound and organizationally relevant, yet these outputs frequently fail to influence the strategic decisions and operational changes they are designed to inform. This analytics–

execution gap represents one of the most significant and underexamined challenges in the field of digital transformation strategy, with direct implications for the design of analytics governance systems, the development of consulting capabilities, and the theory of organizational decision-making (Davenport & Harris, 2017; Kaplan & Norton, 2008).

1.2 The Analytics–Execution Gap

The analytics–execution gap manifests across multiple organizational levels and dimensions. At the strategic level, organizations invest heavily in advanced analytics and AI infrastructure but find that the insights generated by these investments are inconsistently translated into the strategic priorities, resource allocations, and governance decisions that constitute organizational strategy execution. At the operational level, analytics-driven recommendations that have survived governance scrutiny are frequently modified, delayed, or abandoned during implementation, as operational teams encounter the practical constraints that condition the translation of analytical recommendations into organizational action. At the behavioral level, even operationally endorsed analytics outputs — dashboards, threshold alerts, predictive recommendations — are systematically ignored by the organizational actors whose behavior they are designed to influence.

Understanding the analytics–execution gap requires understanding both the structural conditions that produce it and the agentic processes through which it is reproduced, managed, and occasionally overcome. Structural conditions — governance architectures, cultural configurations, resource constraints, power dynamics — create the organizational field within which analytics-driven recommendations must navigate. Agentic processes — the interpretive work of consulting professionals, the political calculations of organizational leaders, the behavioral habits of implementation teams — determine whether analytics insights successfully traverse this field to achieve execution impact.

1.3 Problem Statement

The problem that motivates this study is the theoretical and practical underdevelopment of accounts of the organizational mechanism through which analytics-driven insights are translated into execution-level strategic decisions within consulting-led digital transformation initiatives. While substantial scholarly attention has been devoted to the technical dimensions of analytics capability development and to the governance systems that support strategy execution, comparatively little scholarship has examined the organizational process through which these two domains are connected — the translation mechanism through which analytical outputs generated by one organizational subsystem are mediated, evaluated, and converted into action decisions by another.

This gap in the scholarly literature has direct practical consequences. Consulting professionals who operate at the intersection of analytics capability and strategic execution lack a theoretically grounded model of the translation processes they navigate. Organizations that have invested substantially in analytics infrastructure lack a conceptual framework for diagnosing the organizational conditions that prevent their analytical investments from producing execution-level strategic impact. And scholars who study digital transformation and analytics-driven organizations lack a mechanism-level account of the process that most directly determines whether analytics investment generates organizational value.

1.4 Research Gap

The specific research gap addressed by this study concerns the absence of a theoretically coherent and empirically grounded account of the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism in consulting-led digital transformation contexts. The canonical theoretical corpus — comprising Davenport and Harris (2017), Kaplan and Norton (2008), Mintzberg et al. (1998), Schein and Schein (2016), Rogers (2016), Evans (2017), and Pehrsson (2023) — provides rich theoretical resources for understanding the component

elements of this translation process, but does not synthesize these resources into a unified mechanism-level account. Analytics capability literature addresses the conditions for generating sound analytical insights without theorizing the organizational processes through which those insights are converted into execution decisions. Strategy execution literature addresses the governance systems and management processes that connect strategy to operations without addressing the role of consulting professionals as translation agents within those systems.

The research gap is further specified by the absence of scholarly attention to consulting professionals as a distinctive category of translation agent in the analytics-to-execution process. Consultants occupy a uniquely informative vantage point within this process — positioned at the intersection of analytical generation, governance evaluation, and operational implementation — yet their distinctive contribution to the translation mechanism has not been theorized or empirically investigated in the existing literature.

1.5 Consulting-Led Digital Transformation

The consulting-led digital transformation context provides the institutional setting within which the present study investigates the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism. This context is characterized by the engagement of external consulting professionals to support, guide, and execute digital transformation initiatives within client organizations. Consulting professionals in this context occupy a distinctive intermediary position: they operate within client organizational systems without possessing the formal authority of internal organizational actors, relying instead on their interpretive expertise, analytical capabilities, and relational competencies to influence governance processes and execution decisions.

This intermediary position makes consulting professionals particularly valuable research participants for the present study. Their accounts of analytics-to-execution

translation are shaped by their experience of navigating governance, political, and cultural conditions across multiple client organizations and sectors, providing comparative evidence about the organizational mechanisms that enable or constrain translation across diverse institutional contexts. Multi-sector consulting professionals — those who work across industries rather than within a single sector — offer particularly rich comparative perspectives, enabling the reconstruction of translation mechanisms that are robust across organizational contexts rather than specific to any single industry or institutional setting.

1.6 Research Aim and Objectives

The overarching aim of this study is to reconstruct the organizational mechanism through which consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints. The study does not aim to evaluate the technical quality of analytical inputs, the commercial effectiveness of consulting engagements, or the business outcomes of particular transformation initiatives. Its focus is the translation process itself — the sequence of interpretive, governance, political, and operational mechanisms through which analytical insights are converted into decisions that reshape organizational behavior.

In pursuit of this aim, the study pursues four interconnected objectives. First, it examines how consulting professionals interpret, frame, and operationalize analytics-driven insights during the execution phase of digital transformation initiatives. Second, it identifies and analyzes the structural, cultural, political, and capability-related organizational constraints that shape whether and how analytics insights inform execution-level decisions. Third, it investigates how the governance architecture of analytics capabilities — particularly the configuration of centralization and decentralization — affects decision authority and execution alignment. Fourth, it reconstructs the political and cognitive mediation processes

through which organizational actors accept, reinterpret, or resist analytics-driven recommendations during strategy execution.

1.7 Research Questions

1.7.1 Central Research Question

This study is governed by the following central research question:

How do consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints?

This question positions consulting professionals as the primary mediating actors within the analytics-to-execution translation process. It conceptualizes analytics and AI outputs as sources of strategic insight whose influence on organizational decisions is conditioned rather than direct, identifies execution-level strategic decisions as the focal outcome of interest, and frames organizational constraints as the contextual conditions within which translation processes unfold.

1.7.2 Sub-Research Questions

Four Sub-Research Questions structure the analytical architecture of the study, maintaining a deliberate separation between macro-level organizational conditions and micro-level actor mediation:

SRQ 1: How do consulting professionals interpret, frame, and operationalize analytics-driven insights during the execution phase of digital transformation initiatives?

SRQ 2: What structural, cultural, political, and capability-related constraints shape whether and how analytics-driven insights inform execution-level strategic decisions?

SRQ 3: How does the centralization or decentralization of analytics capabilities affect decision authority, execution speed, and strategic alignment during digital transformation initiatives?

SRQ 4: How do tacit assumptions, cognitive frames, leadership orientations, and political dynamics mediate the acceptance, adaptation, or resistance to analytics-driven recommendations during strategy execution?

1.8 Overview of Theoretical Positioning

This study draws upon a bounded theoretical corpus of seven canonical works that collectively provide the deductive foundation for construct definition, analytical framing, and coding architecture. Digital transformation strategy and multi-sector organizational positioning are informed by Rogers (2016) and Pehrsson (2023). Analytics capability development and governance maturity are grounded in Davenport and Harris (2017) and Evans (2017). Strategy-to-operations alignment and execution system architecture are derived from Kaplan and Norton (2008). Organizational culture, tacit assumptions, and cognitive framing are drawn from Schein and Schein (2016). Structural configurations, power dynamics, and strategy formation processes are informed by Mintzberg et al. (1998).

The study adopts a critical realist ontological position, treating organizational structures, governance systems, cultural configurations, and power dynamics as causally efficacious mechanisms that shape the translation of analytics insights into execution decisions. Epistemologically, the study operates within an interpretivist framework, recognizing that these mechanisms are accessed and reconstructed through the narratives and professional experience of consulting practitioners. Detailed theoretical development and the construction of the conceptual framework are reserved for Chapters 2 and 3 respectively.

1.9 Contribution of the Study

This study makes four interconnected contributions to existing knowledge. The first contribution is theoretical. The study advances understanding of analytics-driven digital transformation by reconstructing the organizational mechanisms through which analytical insights are translated into execution decisions — a process that existing canonical frameworks describe incompletely. By developing the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mediation Framework, the study provides a theoretically grounded and empirically derived model that extends and integrates the existing literature, with each of the seven translation stages anchored in the canonical corpus and validated through the empirical dataset. The study further theorizes the consulting professional as a distinctive translation agent — performing a composite organizational function not reducible to analytical expertise or institutional authority alone.

A second contribution is methodological. The study demonstrates the applicability of abductive mechanism reconstruction to the investigation of organizational translation processes in consulting-led transformation contexts, establishing a replicable analytical procedure for qualitative studies of complex organizational mechanisms in comparable professional settings.

A third contribution is practical. The study provides consulting professionals, organizational leaders, and transformation practitioners with a conceptual framework for diagnosing and addressing the organizational conditions that enable or inhibit the influence of analytics on strategic execution — offering a structured analytical lens that can be operationalized within transformation programs to improve translation outcomes.

The fourth and most theoretically novel contribution is the reconceptualization of execution drift and the identification of the recursive dependency problem. The study reframes execution drift not as an anomalous failure mode but as a constitutive feature of the

translation mechanism under conditions of organizational constraint — a finding that reorients practitioner and theoretical attention from failure prevention toward adaptive translation management. Simultaneously, the recursive dependency problem — the structural condition in which the organizational capabilities required for effective analytics-to-execution translation are precisely the capabilities that analytics-driven transformation is designed to produce — is identified and theorized as a novel organizational phenomenon with direct implications for transformation program sequencing and capability investment strategy.

1.10 Structure of the Thesis

The thesis is organized across nine chapters. Chapter 2 presents a comprehensive review of the relevant theoretical literature, addressing digital transformation strategy, analytics as organizational capability, strategy execution and operational alignment, organizational constraints conditioning analytics adoption, and the theoretical gap motivating the present study. Chapter 3 develops the conceptual framework — the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model — defining core constructs and mapping Sub-Research Questions to theoretical anchors. Chapter 4 presents the methodological architecture, addressing research philosophy, sampling strategy, data collection, ethical considerations, and analytical approach.

Chapter 5 presents the empirical findings organized according to the four Sub-Research Questions (SRQs 1–4), presenting empirical findings thematically across six aggregate dimensions derived from a Gioia data structure constructed through eight semi-structured interviews. A concluding cross-mechanism analysis synthesizes the three recurring mechanism sequences identified across the dataset. Chapter 6 situates the findings within the canonical theoretical literature and develops the refined Analytics-to-Execution Framework. Chapters 7, 8, and 9 address the theoretical and managerial implications of the findings,

methodological limitations and directions for future research, and a concluding synthesis integrating the key contributions of the thesis and projecting their significance for the field of analytics-driven digital transformation strategy.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Digital Business Strategy and Analytics Foundations

2.1.1 Digital Strategy in Complex Organizations

The emergence of digital strategy as a distinctive field of organizational inquiry reflects a fundamental reorientation of competitive logic in the contemporary economic environment. Whereas traditional strategic frameworks positioned competitive advantage as a function of industry structure, resource endowments, or organizational capabilities abstracted from the technological substrate of production, digital strategy frameworks recognize that the technologies of data generation, processing, and distribution have become constitutive of competitive position rather than merely instrumental to its realization (Rogers, 2016; Pehrsson, 2023). The digital transformation of organizational strategy is not, in this framing, a process of technology adoption; it is a process of organizational reconfiguration in which the logic of value creation is restructured around the capabilities of digital systems to generate, analyze, and act on information at scale.

Pehrsson (2023) positions digital business strategy as the integration of digital technologies into the core processes of value creation and competitive positioning, encompassing the full range of organizational decisions about how digital capabilities are deployed across products, services, operational processes, and customer relationships. This framing establishes digital strategy as a meta-level organizational competence that conditions how all other strategic capabilities are developed and deployed, rather than as a functional domain alongside finance, marketing, or operations. For organizations engaged in digital

transformation, this framing has direct implications: the success of transformation initiatives depends not only on the technical quality of digital investments but on the organizational capacity to align those investments with strategic priorities and to embed their outputs into operational decision-making processes.

Rogers (2016) extends this framework by identifying the capacity to use data as a strategic asset as a defining organizational capability of the digital age. Organizations that develop the capability to generate strategic insights from data, to translate those insights into operational decisions, and to adapt their strategies in response to analytically generated evidence are positioned to outcompete organizations that treat digital technologies as operational tools rather than strategic resources. This perspective directly implicates the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism that the present study investigates: the strategic value of analytics investment is realized not at the point of insight generation but at the point of execution decision, and the organizational processes that mediate this translation therefore constitute a critical dimension of digital business strategy.

2.1.2 Analytics as Strategic Capability

Davenport and Harris (2017) provide the canonical theoretical account of analytics as an organizational capability that generates sustainable competitive advantage. Their framework, grounded in extensive empirical investigation of analytically sophisticated organizations across multiple industries, establishes that analytics maturity — the degree to which organizations have developed the data infrastructure, modeling capabilities, leadership commitment, and analytical talent required to generate and deploy analytical insights at scale — is a primary determinant of organizational performance in data-rich competitive environments. Organizations at the highest levels of analytics maturity do not merely use analytics to inform individual decisions; they embed analytical insights into their strategy execution processes, operational workflows, and governance mechanisms, creating an

organizational system in which data-driven decision-making is the default rather than the exception.

The DELTA framework developed by Davenport and Harris (2017) — encompassing Data, Enterprise orientation, Leadership, Targets, and Analysts — identifies the five organizational conditions required for analytics to function as a strategic capability rather than a technical tool. Of particular relevance to the present study are the enterprise orientation condition — the degree to which analytics insights are shared and acted upon across organizational boundaries rather than contained within functional silos — and the leadership condition — the degree to which senior organizational actors model, champion, and enforce the use of analytical evidence in strategic decision-making. These conditions directly correspond to the governance and political-cognitive mediation dimensions of the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism.

Evans (2017) extends the analytics capability framework by addressing the governance dimensions of digital business strategy, arguing that the organizational capacity to deploy digital and analytical capabilities strategically depends on governance architectures that enable analytical insights to be systematically connected to operational decisions. This connection is not automatic; it requires deliberate organizational design of the governance structures, performance management systems, and accountability mechanisms through which analytical insights are evaluated, prioritized, and translated into execution actions. The governance architecture of analytics capability thus constitutes a structural enabling condition for the analytics-to-execution translation process.

2.1.3 From Insight Generation to Organizational Impact

The theoretical gap between the analytics capability literature and the strategy execution literature is most clearly visible in the transition from insight generation to organizational impact. Davenport and Harris (2017) document the organizational conditions

required to generate high-quality analytical insights at scale; Kaplan and Norton (2008) document the governance systems and management processes required to translate strategic priorities into operational execution. What neither body of literature addresses systematically is the organizational process through which analytics insights generated by the first domain are converted into the execution decisions governed by the second. This translation process — the subject of the present study — occupies the theoretical space between analytics capability development and strategy execution governance, a space that the existing canonical literature has not yet mapped with adequate specificity.

2.2 Strategy Execution and Operational Alignment

2.2.1 Strategy-to-Operations Translation

Kaplan and Norton's (2008) execution premium framework provides the most systematically developed account of the organizational processes through which strategic priorities are translated into operational decisions available in the management literature. The framework identifies six management processes — strategy development, strategy translation, organizational alignment, operational planning, monitoring and learning, and testing and adapting — that collectively constitute the institutional architecture through which strategy is connected to operations in high-performing organizations. Each process contributes distinct elements to the strategy-to-execution translation: strategy development establishes strategic priorities; strategy translation converts priorities into measurable targets; organizational alignment ensures that business unit and functional priorities are coordinated with strategic direction; operational planning connects strategic targets to resource allocation decisions; monitoring and learning tracks execution outcomes; and testing and adapting generates feedback that enables strategic learning.

The Balanced Scorecard and strategy map tools that constitute the operational core of the Kaplan and Norton framework are significant not primarily as measurement instruments

but as translation devices — organizational technologies that enable strategic intentions to be communicated, operationalized, and governed across the full complexity of large, multi-unit organizations. By establishing explicit causal relationships between strategic objectives, performance measures, operational targets, and strategic initiatives, these tools create organizational infrastructure through which the connection between strategy formulation and strategy execution is maintained. This infrastructure is directly relevant to the present study's focus on analytics-to-execution translation: the governance processes, performance management systems, and accountability mechanisms that Kaplan and Norton describe are the institutional channels through which analytics-driven recommendations must pass before they can influence execution-level strategic decisions.

2.2.2 Governance Structures and Performance Systems

The governance dimension of the Kaplan and Norton (2008) framework is particularly significant for the present study. The Office of Strategy Management — a dedicated organizational function responsible for coordinating strategy execution processes across business units and functional areas — represents Kaplan and Norton's institutionalized response to the governance challenges that complex strategy execution generates. The OSM's role encompasses the management of strategy review meetings, the coordination of strategic initiative portfolios, and the integration of operational performance feedback into strategic learning processes. Each of these functions corresponds to a dimension of the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism: strategy review meetings are governance forums in which analytical insights may be presented, evaluated, and acted upon; strategic initiative portfolios are the organizational channels through which analytics-driven recommendations are resourced and executed; and strategic learning processes are the feedback mechanisms through which execution outcomes inform subsequent analytical priorities.

The STRATEX concept — Strategic Expenditure, referring to dedicated funding streams for strategic initiatives that are explicitly separated from operational budgets — addresses the resource allocation dimension of strategy-to-execution translation. STRATEX mechanisms are designed to prevent strategically important initiatives from being competed away by operational budget pressures, creating protected resource channels through which analytical recommendations can be resourced without competing against established operational priorities. The empirical evidence examined in Chapter 5 suggests that STRATEX-type mechanisms are rarely operative in the client organizations that participants describe, creating a structural resource constraint that the Budget-Lock-Drift failure sequence directly reflects.

2.2.3 Execution Drift and Breakdown Patterns

The gap between intended and realized strategy is a foundational observation in the strategic management literature. Mintzberg et al. (1998) characterize this gap as a fundamental feature of organizational strategy formation, distinguishing between deliberate strategies — those that are realized as intended through explicit organizational planning — and emergent strategies — those that arise through organizational process without explicit prior intention. The space between intended and realized strategy is populated by unrealized strategies — deliberate intentions that fail to achieve execution — and emergent strategies — realized patterns that were not explicitly intended. This conceptual framework, while developed in the context of strategy formation generally rather than analytics-to-execution translation specifically, provides a theoretical vocabulary for understanding execution drift as a constitutive rather than anomalous feature of the translation mechanism.

The strategy execution literature documents a range of breakdown patterns through which intended strategies fail to achieve realization. These patterns include strategic misalignment — the failure to connect strategic priorities to operational decision-making

processes — execution capability gaps — the absence of the organizational skills, knowledge, and resources required to implement strategic intentions — and governance fragmentation — the failure of coordination mechanisms that are supposed to ensure strategic alignment across organizational units. Each of these breakdown patterns corresponds to dimensions of the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism: misalignment between analytical recommendations and organizational strategic priorities produces governance rejection; capability gaps prevent analytical insights from being operationalized effectively; governance fragmentation creates the silo effects that prevent analytics-driven coordination across organizational units.

2.3 Organizational Constraints in Digital Transformation

2.3.1 Structural Governance Constraints

Structural constraints on the analytics-to-execution translation process derive from the governance architectures, approval processes, regulatory requirements, and organizational boundaries that characterize the institutional environments within which digital transformation initiatives unfold. Kaplan and Norton (2008) identify governance architecture as a fundamental determinant of strategy execution effectiveness: organizations with well-designed governance systems that explicitly connect strategic decision-making to operational implementation outperform those with fragmented or incoherent governance arrangements. In the analytics context, governance architecture determines not only whether analytical insights are evaluated by the appropriate decision makers but also whether the evaluation criteria applied to those insights are strategically coherent or reflect the fragmented priorities of competing organizational units.

Multi-level approval structures represent a particularly consequential form of structural constraint on analytics-to-execution translation. In complex organizations, analytics-driven recommendations must typically traverse multiple governance layers —

technical validation, strategic relevance assessment, financial viability review, and board-level authorization — before receiving execution approval. Each layer applies distinct evaluative criteria that may not be fully aligned with the analytical logic of the recommendation under review. The cumulative effect of multi-layer approval is to impose serial constraint on the translation process: a recommendation that succeeds at the first governance layer may fail at the second on entirely different grounds, and the probability of successful translation diminishes with each additional governance stage.

2.3.2 Cultural and Cognitive Constraints

Schein and Schein (2016) provide the foundational theoretical account of organizational culture as a system of shared tacit assumptions that conditions how organizational members perceive, evaluate, and respond to strategic information. Organizational culture, in this framework, is not merely a set of espoused values or behavioral norms; it is a deep structure of cognitive and evaluative assumptions that shapes how actors within the organization interpret their environment, make decisions, and coordinate with one another. These deep cultural assumptions operate largely below the level of conscious reflection, shaping organizational behavior through the tacit frameworks that organizational members have internalized through their participation in organizational life.

The implications of this cultural framework for the analytics-to-execution translation process are direct and consequential. In organizations where the dominant cognitive frames treat analytical evidence as a secondary input to decision-making — subordinate to experiential judgment, relational trust, and organizational hierarchy — analytics-driven recommendations will systematically face cultural resistance regardless of their technical quality. The analytical validity of a recommendation does not automatically generate organizational receptivity; receptivity is a cultural condition that must be actively cultivated through the interpretive and relational work of translation agents. Understanding how

cognitive frames condition the reception of analytical recommendations is therefore essential to reconstructing the mechanisms through which the analytics–execution gap is produced.

2.3.3 Political and Power Dynamics

Political dynamics within organizations represent a third category of constraints on analytics-to-execution translation. Mintzberg et al. (1998) provide a comprehensive account of organizational politics as an inherent feature of strategy formation in complex organizations, arising from the enduring differences in values, interests, and perceptions that characterize organizational coalitions and from the competition for scarce resources that these differences engender. Strategy formation in politically complex organizations is not a process of rational deliberation leading to optimal decisions; it is a process of bargaining, negotiation, and coalition-building through which competing interests are accommodated, compromised, and partially reconciled. Strategies — including analytics-driven recommendations — that emerge from this process will reflect not only the analytical evidence from which they originate but also the political conditions under which they are evaluated and approved.

Political constraints operate at multiple levels of the analytics-to-execution process. At the level of individual decision makers, political interests may lead leaders to discount, modify, or reject analytical recommendations that threaten established power relationships, challenge entrenched priorities, or imply resource reallocation away from politically powerful organizational units. At the level of organizational coalitions, competing groups may mobilize different analytical framings of the same underlying data to support their preferred strategic directions, producing governance processes in which analytical evidence is deployed rhetorically rather than serving as a genuine basis for decision-making. At the level of organizational politics more broadly, the ability to control which analytical insights receive governance attention — through agenda-setting, information management, and informal influence networks — constitutes a form of political power that can decisively shape which

analytics-driven recommendations ultimately influence execution decisions (Mintzberg et al., 1998).

The relationship between political dynamics and consulting professionals is particularly significant for the present study. Consultants who operate within client organizations necessarily navigate the political landscape of those organizations, and the effectiveness of their interpretive and mediating functions depends on their capacity to build coalitions of support for analytics-driven recommendations, to anticipate and address political objections before they become governance obstacles, and to frame analytical insights in ways that align with the interests and priorities of key political actors. The political dimension of consulting practice thus constitutes an important and underexamined aspect of the analytics-to-execution translation process.

2.3.4 Resource-Based Constraints

Resource constraints constitute a fourth category of organizational conditions that shape the translation of analytics insights into execution decisions. These constraints operate across three principal dimensions: data and infrastructure quality, human capital, and financial and time resources. Davenport and Harris (2017) identify data quality as a foundational constraint on analytics effectiveness: organizations that lack integrated, consistent, and reliable data infrastructure cannot generate the analytical outputs required to inform strategy execution, regardless of the sophistication of their modelling tools or the commitment of their leadership to data-driven decision-making. Legacy systems, fragmented data architectures, and inconsistent data standards create conditions in which analytical insights may be generated from incomplete or unreliable data, limiting both the quality of recommendations and the organizational confidence in analytical outputs.

Human capital constraints represent an equally significant resource-based limitation on analytics-to-execution translation. The translation of analytical outputs into execution-

level strategic decisions requires professionals who combine analytical literacy — the capacity to interpret and evaluate analytical outputs critically — with organizational and strategic competence — the capacity to understand the implications of those outputs for strategy execution, to communicate them effectively to non-technical audiences, and to navigate the governance and political processes through which they must pass. This combination of capabilities is scarce in most organizations and must often be provided or supplemented by consulting professionals engaged specifically for this bridging function (Evans, 2017; Rogers, 2016). The availability of such bridge-building human capital constitutes a critical resource constraint on the analytics–execution translation process.

2.4 Analytical Lenses for Understanding Execution Under Constraint

The theoretical literature reviewed in the preceding sections provides a set of analytical lenses through which the empirical findings of this study can be interpreted. These lenses do not constitute a unified theoretical framework; rather, they represent complementary perspectives that illuminate different dimensions of the analytics-to-execution translation process. Their integration in the analysis of empirical findings enables a more complete reconstruction of the mechanisms through which analytical insights are mediated, modified, and operationalized within constrained organizational environments.

The first lens — derived from Davenport and Harris (2017) and Evans (2017) — focuses on analytics capability and governance architecture as structural conditions that enable or constrain the generation and flow of analytical insights within organizations. In the empirical analysis, this lens is employed to examine how the centralization or decentralization of analytics governance affects the pathways through which insights travel toward decision makers and the conditions under which governance architecture enables or constrains analytics influence.

The second lens — derived from Kaplan and Norton (2008) — focuses on strategy execution systems and performance governance as the institutional channels through which analytics insights are evaluated, approved, and translated into operational decisions. In the empirical analysis, this lens is employed to examine how the formal governance processes of client organizations filter, delay, or modify analytics-driven recommendations as they move from generation to implementation.

The third lens — derived from Mintzberg et al. (1998) and Schein and Schein (2016) — focuses on political dynamics, cognitive frames, and organizational culture as mediating conditions that shape how individual actors and organizational coalitions respond to analytical recommendations. In the empirical analysis, this lens is employed to examine how tacit assumptions, leadership orientations, political interests, and cultural norms condition the reception and operationalization of analytics-driven insights within client organizations. Together, these three lenses constitute the analytical architecture applied in Chapter 5 to reconstruct the mechanisms of analytics-to-execution translation from the empirical findings.

2.5 Contextual Industry Exemplars

The following three contextual examples are drawn from the empirical and practitioner literature on digital transformation. They serve an illustrative function, providing organizational grounding for the theoretical mechanisms discussed in this chapter. They are not treated as empirical evidence within the present study; primary empirical evidence is derived exclusively from the interview dataset. These examples are presented to contextualize the theoretical arguments of the literature review and to orient the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 3.

2.5.1 AI Industrialization in Banking — DBS Bank

DBS Bank's AI transformation, documented extensively in practitioner and academic literature and examined in a Harvard Business School case study (2024), represents one of

the most comprehensively reported instances of centralized AI industrialization in the financial services sector. DBS pursued a deliberate strategy of treating AI not as a discrete technology investment but as an enterprise-wide capability requiring systematic governance, standardized data infrastructure, and the organizational redesign of decision processes to incorporate AI-generated insights into routine operational and strategic decisions. The bank developed an AI factory model that centralized data governance, model development, and deployment standards while distributing AI-enabled decision support across business units — an approach that combined the governance coherence of centralization with the operational relevance of distributed application.

What the DBS case illustrates, within the theoretical framework developed in this chapter, is the enabling effect of deliberate governance architecture on the analytics-to-execution translation process. By investing in the organizational and governance conditions — data standards, model governance, leadership commitment, and performance measurement integration — that enable analytical outputs to be systematically connected to operational decisions, DBS reduced the structural, cultural, and governance barriers through which analytics insights must otherwise pass before influencing execution. This example thus provides contextual grounding for the theoretical argument that analytics governance architecture constitutes a critical structural condition for the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism.

2.5.2 AI-Driven Process Reengineering in Insurance — If P&C

The AI-enabled operational transformation of If P&C Insurance illustrates the application of predictive and prescriptive analytics to the reengineering of core operational processes in the insurance sector. If P&C's implementation of AI-driven claims processing, risk assessment, and customer interaction automation demonstrates the operational impact of embedding analytical models directly into process workflows — a configuration in which the

translation from analytical insight to operational action is architecturally instantiated rather than requiring organizational mediation for each individual decision. This approach substantially reduces the human interpretive and political mediation required to operationalize analytics insights, as the governance structure of the technology platform itself determines the conditions under which analytical recommendations are applied to operational decisions.

The If P&C case thus illustrates a configuration of analytics-to-execution translation in which the analytics–execution gap is partially closed through process automation rather than through the organizational mediation that characterizes the consulting-led transformation contexts examined in the present study. It provides a useful comparative reference for understanding the distinct mechanisms through which analytics influences execution in contexts where human intermediation remains central — as it does in the complex, multi-stakeholder environments that consulting professionals navigate — as opposed to contexts where automation enables more direct analytics-to-action pathways.

2.5.3 High-Profile Digital Transformation Failure — GE Digital/Predix

The trajectory of GE Digital and the Predix industrial IoT platform constitutes one of the most extensively analyzed cases of digital transformation failure in the management literature. GE invested several billion dollars in the development of Predix as an enterprise-wide platform for AI-driven industrial analytics, with the strategic intention of establishing GE as a leading digital industrial company capable of monetizing analytics-derived insights at scale. The initiative's subsequent contraction and strategic retreat — involving the sale of digital assets, restructuring of leadership, and substantial write-down of investments — provides an instructive illustration of the conditions under which ambitious analytics-driven transformation strategies fail to translate into sustained execution impact.

The GE Digital failure illustrates several of the theoretical mechanisms developed in this chapter. The misalignment between the analytics-driven strategic vision articulated by senior leadership and the execution capabilities, governance structures, and organizational culture of GE's established industrial business units produced classic execution drift: the intended strategy diverged progressively from the emergent strategy as business unit leaders, governance bodies, and operational teams responded to the analytics-driven transformation initiative in ways shaped by their own organizational contexts, resource constraints, and political interests (Mintzberg et al., 1998; Rogers, 2016). The case demonstrates that the analytics–execution gap is not merely a technical challenge but a systemic organizational challenge in which structural, cultural, political, and resource-based constraints interact to prevent analytics-driven insights from reshaping organizational behavior at scale.

2.6 Theoretical Synthesis and Research Proposition

2.6.1 The Missing Translation Mechanism

While existing scholarship has extensively examined analytics capability development, digital transformation strategy, and strategy execution systems, comparatively little scholarship has examined the organizational mechanisms through which analytics-driven insights are translated into execution-level strategic decisions. In particular, little attention has been given to how governance structures, cultural dynamics, and political considerations mediate this translation process. This study addresses this gap by developing and empirically examining an analytics-to-execution translation mechanism based on qualitative evidence from consulting practitioners engaged in digital transformation initiatives across multiple sectors.

The literature reviewed in this chapter provides rich and well-developed accounts of the distinct components of the analytics-to-execution relationship — analytics capability development, strategy execution systems, organizational culture, political dynamics, and

resource constraints. What this literature does not provide, however, is a coherent account of the translation mechanism through which these components interact sequentially to produce — or fail to produce — execution-level strategic decisions from analytics insights. The literature treats the generation of analytical insight and the execution of strategic decisions as analytically separable phenomena, each with its own theoretical apparatus. But the organizational process through which insights travel from generation to execution — the interpretive, governance, political, and operational sequence through which analytical recommendations become organizational action — remains theoretically underspecified.

2.6.2 Limits of Canonical Execution Frameworks

The canonical execution frameworks developed by Kaplan and Norton (2008) provide the most systematically developed account of strategy-to-operations translation available in the literature. Yet these frameworks were developed primarily in the context of organizational self-governance — the systems through which senior leaders manage the relationship between strategy and operations within their own organizations. They do not address the distinctive challenges that arise when the translation function is performed by external professionals — consultants — who lack formal authority within the client organization and must therefore rely on interpretive, political, and relational capabilities to influence governance processes and execution decisions. The Balanced Scorecard and strategy map frameworks assume a degree of organizational alignment, governance coherence, and leadership commitment that may not characterize the complex, contested environments in which consulting-led digital transformation typically unfolds.

Similarly, the organizational culture and power dynamics literature provides important theoretical resources for understanding the constraints on analytics adoption, but it does not reconstruct the specific sequential mechanism through which these constraints operate within the analytics-to-execution process. Culture and power are treated as

background conditions that shape organizational behavior rather than as active mechanisms that intervene at specific points in the translation process — selecting, filtering, and modifying analytical insights as they move through the organizational system toward execution decisions. Reconstructing these mechanisms in their sequential specificity requires an empirical approach that moves beyond the existing theoretical frameworks and investigates the translation process as it unfolds in the accounts of practitioners who participate in it.

2.6.3 Positioning of the Present Study

The present study is positioned at the intersection of the theoretical domains reviewed in this chapter, addressing the gap between the analytics capability literature's account of insight generation and the strategy execution literature's account of operational decision-making. Its contribution is not to challenge or replace the canonical frameworks but to extend and integrate them by reconstructing the organizational mechanisms that link insight generation to execution decisions — mechanisms that existing frameworks presuppose but do not theorize. By investigating these mechanisms through the professional accounts of consulting practitioners engaged in analytics-driven digital transformation, the study generates an empirically grounded and theoretically anchored account of the analytics-to-execution translation process that neither the analytics capability literature nor the strategy execution literature currently provides.

The research proposition that guides empirical inquiry may be stated as follows: the translation of analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within consulting-led digital transformation initiatives is not a direct or automatic process but a multi-stage organizational mechanism mediated by the interpretive work of consulting professionals, the governance architecture of client organizations, the cultural and cognitive frameworks of decision makers, and the political dynamics through which competing

organizational interests are negotiated. This proposition frames the Central Research Question and the four Sub-Research Questions and provides the theoretical foundation for the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 3.

3. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

3.1 Scope Refinement and Conceptual Delimitation

The originally approved thesis proposal framed the study as a cross-sector investigation of how consulting professionals leverage analytics-driven approaches across multiple industries, with particular emphasis on similarities and differences between sectors. While this broader framing remains aligned with the registered thesis title, deeper theoretical engagement with the core literature revealed that sectoral variation, although relevant, did not constitute the primary explanatory dimension of interest.

The conceptual focus of the present study is deliberately delimited to the organizational mechanism through which analytics-driven insights are translated into execution-level strategic decisions under varying organizational constraints. The structural, political, and cultural dynamics shaping this translation process transcend sector boundaries, making mechanism-centered explanation more analytically productive than cross-sector comparative description. This delimitation is a deliberate design choice that enhances explanatory precision and ensures that the empirical investigation remains tightly organized around the study's central research question.

Importantly, this refinement does not represent a change in the overarching research domain but rather a conceptual delimitation designed to enhance explanatory precision. The registered thesis title — Multi-Sector Consulting: Analytics-Driven Approaches to Digital Transformation Strategy — continues to frame the empirical field appropriately. However, the present study narrows its analytical lens to consulting professionals irrespective of sector

classification, emphasizing underlying governance structures, centralization dynamics (Davenport & Harris, 2017), strategy-to-execution linkages (Kaplan & Norton, 2008), and political-cultural constraints (Mintzberg et al., 1998; Schein & Schein, 2016).

Accordingly, findings are structured thematically around mechanism-level dimensions — such as analytics centralization, governance architecture, cognitive resistance, and execution constraints — rather than organized by sectoral comparison. This shift reflects a movement from descriptive mapping toward explanatory depth, consistent with the study's critical realist ontology and interpretivist epistemology. By analytically delimiting the scope in this manner, the research enhances theoretical coherence while preserving full continuity with the approved research domain.

3.2 Overview of the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model

3.2.1 Core Analytical Logic

The Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model (hereafter the Translation Model) is the conceptual framework through which the present study organizes its empirical investigation and develops its theoretical contribution. The Translation Model conceptualizes the conversion of analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions not as a linear or automatic process but as a multi-stage organizational mechanism — a structured sequence of interpretive, governance, political, and operational processes through which analytical outputs are successively mediated, modified, and operationalized within the constraints of organizational systems. The model does not evaluate the technical quality of analytical inputs; its analytical focus is the organizational process through which those inputs travel from generation to execution.

The core analytical logic of the Translation Model is grounded in the theoretical synthesis developed in Chapter 2. From Davenport and Harris (2017) and Evans (2017), the model derives its conceptualization of analytics capability and governance architecture as

structural enabling conditions that determine the quality, scope, and organizational accessibility of analytical insights. From Kaplan and Norton (2008), the model derives its account of strategy execution systems and governance processes as the institutional channels through which analytical recommendations are evaluated and approved. From Mintzberg et al. (1998) and Schein and Schein (2016), the model derives its account of political dynamics, cognitive frames, and organizational culture as mediating conditions that shape how actors within these channels receive, interpret, and respond to analytical recommendations.

3.2.2 Layered Structure–Agency Relationship

The Translation Model is organized around a layered structure–agency relationship that captures the interaction between macro-level organizational conditions and micro-level actor behavior in shaping the analytics-to-execution process. At the structural level, the model recognizes that organizations are characterized by governance architectures, cultural configurations, resource distributions, and political arrangements that preexist and condition the translation process. These structural conditions are not deterministic; they do not mechanically produce particular translation outcomes. Rather, they constitute the organizational field within which consulting professionals and organizational leaders exercise interpretive, communicative, and political agency.

At the agency level, the model recognizes that consulting professionals occupy a distinctive intermediary position within this field. They interpret analytical outputs and reframe them as strategic arguments. They navigate governance processes and build organizational coalitions of support. They manage political dynamics and cultural resistances. And they adapt recommendations to the operational realities of client implementation contexts. The effectiveness of this agency is conditioned but not determined by structural factors: the same analytical recommendation may succeed in one organizational context and

fail in another, depending on the governance architecture, cultural orientation, and political landscape that consulting professionals must navigate.

3.3 Definition of Core Constructs

3.3.1 Analytics Capability

Analytics capability is defined, following Davenport and Harris (2017), as the organizational capacity to generate, interpret, and act on data-derived insights at a scale and quality sufficient to inform strategic and operational decisions. Analytics capability encompasses the technical infrastructure of data collection, storage, and processing; the modeling and analytical expertise required to generate insights from data; the governance architecture through which analytical functions are organized and coordinated; and the organizational culture and leadership orientation that condition whether analytical outputs are treated as strategically significant inputs to decision-making. Analytics capability is a structural enabling condition for the translation mechanism: without adequate analytics capability, the insights required to initiate the translation process cannot be generated with sufficient quality or organizational credibility to survive governance scrutiny.

For the purposes of the present study, analytics capability is treated as an exogenous variable — a condition that varies across client organizations and that consulting professionals must assess and account for in designing their translation strategies, but that is not itself the object of analytical investigation. The study focuses on the mechanisms through which available analytics capability is translated into execution decisions rather than on the conditions required to develop analytics capability in the first place.

3.3.2 Consultant-Led Translation Mechanisms

Consultant-led translation mechanisms are the interpretive, communicative, governance, and operational activities through which consulting professionals convert analytics-derived insights into execution-level strategic decisions within client organizations.

Four primary translation mechanisms are identified within the conceptual framework, each corresponding to a distinct dimension of the consultant's translation function.

3.3.2.1 Interpretation and Framing

Interpretation and framing refers to the active process through which consulting professionals convert technical analytical outputs — statistical models, predictive forecasts, performance dashboards, scenario analyses — into strategic arguments calibrated to the cognitive frameworks, institutional priorities, and decision-making contexts of organizational audiences. This mechanism reflects Rogers's (2016) account of data strategy, which positions the organizational translation of analytical outputs as a deliberate communicative activity requiring expertise in both analytical interpretation and organizational communication. Framing is not merely a presentational choice; it constitutes a substantive interpretive activity through which the strategic implications of analytical evidence are constructed, prioritized, and directed toward specific organizational decision points.

3.3.2.2 Governance Filtering

Governance filtering refers to the process through which analytics-driven recommendations are evaluated, approved, or rejected by the formal governance structures of client organizations. This mechanism reflects Kaplan and Norton's (2008) account of strategy execution governance, which identifies formal review processes, approval committees, and budget authorization mechanisms as the institutional channels through which strategic intentions are evaluated against organizational criteria before being resourced for execution. Within the translation mechanism, governance filtering operates as the primary institutional constraint on analytics influence: recommendations that fail governance evaluation do not proceed to execution regardless of their analytical quality, making governance navigation a critical dimension of the consultant's translation function.

3.3.2.3 Political Negotiation

Political negotiation refers to the informal processes through which consulting professionals build organizational support for analytics-driven recommendations by engaging the political dynamics of client organizations. This mechanism reflects Mintzberg et al.'s (1998) Power School account of strategy formation, which characterizes strategic decisions as the outcomes of political processes in which competing interests, values, and organizational coalitions shape which recommendations receive organizational attention and support. Effective political negotiation requires consulting professionals to identify and engage key stakeholders whose support is necessary for governance approval, to anticipate and pre-empt political objections, and to align analytical recommendations with the interests and priorities of influential organizational actors.

3.3.2.4 Narrative Construction

Narrative construction refers to the process through which consulting professionals develop and communicate strategic narratives that connect analytical evidence to organizational action. This mechanism reflects the cultural and cognitive dimensions of Schein and Schein's (2016) framework, which identifies shared tacit assumptions and cognitive frames as the deep structures through which organizational actors interpret and evaluate strategic information. Effective narrative construction requires consulting professionals to develop communication strategies that resonate with the dominant cultural assumptions and cognitive frames of organizational decision makers — framing analytical recommendations not merely as evidence but as stories about organizational opportunity, risk, or transformation that align with the cultural logic of the client organization.

3.3.3 Organizational Constraint Typology

The organizational constraint typology defines four categories of structural condition that shape the analytics-to-execution translation process by limiting the pathways through

which analytical recommendations can move from generation to execution. Each category is theoretically grounded in the canonical corpus and operationalized as a distinct coding domain in the empirical analysis. First, structural and governance constraints — grounded in Kaplan and Norton's (2008) execution premium framework — encompass the formal organizational structures including approval hierarchies, regulatory requirements, and functional boundaries that determine the institutional routes through which recommendations must travel. Second, resource and capability constraints — developed through Davenport and Harris's (2017) analytics maturity model — encompass the financial, temporal, and human capital limitations that condition the organizational capacity to implement analytics-driven recommendations. Third, accountability and incentive constraints encompass the absence of clear ownership of recommendations and the misalignment between individual actor incentives and collective analytics-to-execution objectives, producing the risk-averse middle management dynamics that systematically suppress analytically supported initiatives. Fourth, cultural constraints — theorized through Schein and Schein's (2016) framework of shared tacit assumptions — encompass the sector-specific norms and dominant cognitive frames that condition how organizational actors perceive, evaluate, and respond to analytical evidence.

3.3.4 Strategic Execution Decisions

Strategic execution decisions are defined as organizational decisions that commit resources, restructure processes, or reallocate organizational attention in response to analytically generated evidence. These decisions constitute the terminal outcome of the analytics-to-execution translation process: they represent the point at which analytical insights have successfully traversed the interpretation, governance, political, and operational stages of the translation mechanism and have been converted into organizational action. The present study treats execution decisions not as binary outcomes — either an insight achieves execution or it does not — but as outcomes along a spectrum of translation fidelity,

acknowledging that the analytical content of recommendations is typically modified through the translation process and that the relationship between the original analytical insight and the final execution decision reflects the cumulative effects of governance filtering, political negotiation, and operational adaptation.

3.4 SRQ–Construct Mapping

Table 3.1 presents the mapping between Sub-Research Questions, core constructs, canonical theoretical anchors, key sub-codes, and interview operationalization strategies. This mapping establishes the analytical architecture through which the empirical investigation is organized and ensures that each Sub-Research Question is addressed through a theoretically coherent set of constructs and empirical indicators.

Table 3.1 SRQ–Construct Mapping and Analytical Alignment

SRQ	Core Construct	Canonical Anchors	Key Sub-Codes	Interview Operationalization
SRQ 1	Consultant Interpretation and Operationalization	Davenport & Harris (2017); Rogers (2016); Evans (2017)	Analytical reframing; narrative construction; audience-specific communication; staged proof-of-concept demonstration; revenue-linked prioritization; four-stage interpret–decide–	Questions 5–14

			execute– measure sequence	
SRQ 2	Structural, Cultural, and Resource- Based Organizational Constraints	Kaplan & Norton (2008); Schein & Schein (2016); Mintzberg et al. (1998)	Approval process requirements; functional boundary effects; resource limitations; data quality constraints; cultural norms; cognitive frames; incentive misalignment; accountability gaps; legacy system dependencies	Questions 15–18
SRQ 3	Governance Architecture and Configuration	Evans (2017); Davenport & Harris (2017)	Centralized analytics functions; decentralized analytics functions; hybrid hub-and- spoke models; analytics centre of excellence structures; data platform ownership; governance	Questions 19–21

			standardization; execution speed dynamics; decision authority distribution	
SRQ 4	Political and Cognitive Mediation Dynamics	Mintzberg et al. (1998); Schein & Schein (2016)	Leadership cognitive framing; political risk calculation; informal power networks; trusted advisor influence; cultural selective adoption; cognitive resistance; stakeholder defensiveness; alert fatigue; political override dynamics	Questions 22–25

Note. Author's own construction.

3.5 Visual Representation

Table 3.2 presents the seven-stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mediation Framework. As noted in Section 3.2, this framework is not a rigid linear sequence but an analytical map of the principal processes through which analytics insights are mediated on

their path toward execution. The Translation Mediation Framework is not presented as a standalone figure owing to the complexity of its relational structure; the tabular representation provides greater analytical clarity and enables the explicit mapping of each stage to key actors, organizational roles, interview references, and Sub-Research Question linkages.

Table 3.2 Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mediation Framework

Stage	Stage Name	Process Description	Key Actors	Organizational Role	Interview References	SRQ
1	Insight Generation	Analytics insights produced through dashboards, predictive models, and integrated data platforms that transform organizational data into analytical outputs.	Data scientists, analytics teams, data engineers	Generation of analytical insights from organizational data.	INT-01, INT-02, INT-03, INT-08	SRQ 3
2	Interpretive Mediation	Analytics outputs translated into business-relevant narratives so decision makers can understand strategic and operational implications.	Consultants, analytics translators, hybrid data-business teams	Interpretation and framing of analytics insights for managerial decision making.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-06, INT-07	SRQ 1

3	Governance Mediation	Analytics recommendations reviewed within formal governance structures such as steering committees or executive review forums before execution approval.	Steering committees, senior managers, governance boards	Organizational filtering and approval of analytics-driven initiatives.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-05	SRQ 2
4	Political– Cognitive Mediation	Leaders interpret analytics insights through prior experience, organizational culture, and informal influence networks that shape whether insights are accepted or challenged.	Executives, senior leaders, influential stakeholders	Cognitive framing and political negotiation of analytics recommendations.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	SRQ 4
5	Execution Decision	Final decisions regarding implementation taken by business leaders responsible for operational performance and strategic outcomes.	Business unit leaders, operational managers	Determining whether analytics insights proceed into execution.	INT-02, INT-03, INT-04, INT-07, INT-08	SRQ 1

6	Operational Adaptation	Operational teams modify analytics recommendations to align with existing workflows, operational constraints, and practical implementation realities.	Department managers, operational teams	Adaptation of analytics insights during execution.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	SRQ 1
7	Implementation and Performance Monitoring	Implemented initiatives evaluated through KPIs, testing mechanisms, and performance monitoring systems that track outcomes of analytics-driven decisions.	Operational leaders, analytics teams	Measurement of execution outcomes and organizational impact.	INT-08	SRQ 2

Note. Author's own construction.

3.6 Analytical Orientation for Empirical Inquiry

The Translation Model developed in this chapter provides the analytical architecture for the empirical investigation presented in Chapters 4 and 5. It establishes the constructs to be investigated, the theoretical relationships to be examined, and the analytical questions to be pursued through the interview dataset. The model is applied abductively: empirical findings are examined in light of the theoretical constructs and relationships the model

specifies, but the analysis remains open to the emergence of themes, mechanisms, and relationships that extend or refine the model's initial formulation. This abductive orientation reflects the critical realist commitments of the study — the recognition that organizational mechanisms cannot be directly observed but must be reconstructed through the interpretive accounts of participants who have engaged with them in practice.

The Translation Model thus serves a dual function in the study's analytical architecture. It provides a deductive scaffold that ensures the empirical analysis is theoretically disciplined — anchored in the canonical literature and organized around constructs and relationships derived from established theoretical frameworks. And it provides an inductive horizon that remains open to the emergence of mechanisms, conditions, and processes that the existing literature has not yet theorized. Together, these functions enable the study to generate an empirically grounded and theoretically integrated account of the analytics-to-execution translation process — an account that advances beyond the canonical frameworks while remaining anchored in their conceptual resources. Chapter 4 presents the methodological architecture through which this abductive empirical inquiry is designed and executed.

4. METHODOLOGY

4.1 Research Philosophy and Approach

4.1.1 Critical Realist Ontology

The present study adopts a critical realist ontological position. Critical realism holds that organizational reality consists of structures, mechanisms, and causal powers that exist independently of whether they are directly observed or recognized by the organizational actors who operate within them (Bhaskar, 1978). From this perspective, the governance architectures, cultural configurations, power dynamics, and resource constraints that

condition the translation of analytics insights into execution decisions are not merely interpretive constructs or discursive formations; they are real causal mechanisms with genuine effects on organizational behavior. The analytics–execution gap is not a perception or a narrative; it is a structural condition produced by the operation of real organizational mechanisms that this study seeks to reconstruct.

Critical realism distinguishes between three levels of reality: the empirical domain, comprising events and experiences that are observed; the actual domain, comprising events that occur whether or not they are observed; and the real domain, comprising the underlying structures and mechanisms that produce observable events. The translation of analytics insights into execution decisions is an event in the actual domain — it occurs across multiple organizational settings, whether or not researchers observe it. The mechanisms that produce or prevent this translation are located in the real domain — they are the structural conditions and agentive processes that generate observable patterns of analytics influence and non-influence. The empirical domain, accessed through the interview accounts of consulting professionals, provides the observational evidence from which real-domain mechanisms are reconstructed through theoretical inference.

This ontological positioning has direct implications for the study's analytical objectives. The study does not merely seek to describe the experiences of consulting professionals in analytics-driven transformation; it seeks to reconstruct the mechanisms that produce those experiences — the underlying organizational processes through which analytics insights are mediated, filtered, and operationalized. This mechanism-reconstruction objective distinguishes the present study from purely interpretivist qualitative research and grounds it in the explanatory ambitions of critical realism: the aim is not only to understand but to explain by identifying the real causal structures that generate the observable patterns of analytics influence that the study investigates.

4.1.2 Interpretivist Epistemology

While the study's ontological commitments are critical realist, its epistemological approach is interpretivist. The underlying mechanisms that produce the analytics–execution gap cannot be directly observed; they must be reconstructed through the interpretive accounts of practitioners who have engaged with them in concrete organizational contexts. Semi-structured interviews with consulting professionals provide the primary epistemic route of access to these mechanisms — not because practitioner accounts are identical with the mechanisms themselves, but because those accounts, interpreted through an analytically informed theoretical framework, provide reliable evidence from which mechanisms can be inferred.

This epistemological position reflects the inherent nature of the phenomenon under investigation. The translation of analytics insights into execution decisions is a social process enacted by organizational actors whose interpretations, motivations, and judgments constitute integral dimensions of the mechanism being reconstructed. Understanding this process requires understanding how consulting professionals experience and make sense of the organizational conditions they navigate — how they interpret governance resistance, negotiate political dynamics, and adapt analytical recommendations to organizational realities. These experiential and interpretive dimensions are not epiphenomenal; they are constitutive of the translation mechanism itself. Interpretivist methods are therefore not merely methodologically convenient for this study; they are epistemologically necessary for accessing the agentic dimension of the mechanism that critical realism identifies as causally significant.

The combination of critical realist ontology and interpretivist epistemology produces a research design that is neither purely positivist nor purely constructivist. It is empirically grounded in the accounts of practitioners, theoretically anchored in the canonical literature,

and analytically oriented toward mechanism reconstruction rather than either statistical generalization or purely descriptive phenomenology.

4.2 Research Scope and Analytical Delimitation

The present study is subject to several deliberate conceptual delimitations that reflect the analytical narrowing required to maintain the focus and coherence of the research design. First, the study investigates the translation mechanism from the perspective of consulting professionals rather than from the perspective of organizational clients, business unit leaders, or analytics specialists. This delimitation reflects a methodological choice: consulting professionals are positioned to observe the translation process from its most complex vantage point — the intersection of analytics generation, governance evaluation, and operational implementation — making their accounts particularly informative for the reconstruction of the full translation mechanism.

Second, the study focuses on analytics-to-execution translation within the context of digital transformation initiatives rather than across all organizational decision contexts. This delimitation reflects the theoretical logic of the study: digital transformation initiatives are the organizational contexts in which analytics and AI capabilities are most systematically deployed for strategic effect, making them the empirically productive setting in which the translation mechanism can be most clearly observed and reconstructed. The study does not claim that its findings generalize to all analytics-influenced decisions across all organizational types; it aims for analytical generalization — the identification of mechanisms and conditions that illuminate the translation process in analogous consulting-led transformation contexts.

Third, the study does not evaluate the quality, accuracy, or strategic soundness of the analytical recommendations that consulting professionals describe. Its analytical focus is the organizational mechanism through which recommendations are processed — not the

recommendations themselves. This delimitation prevents the study from collapsing into a normative assessment of consulting practice and maintains its analytical focus on the organizational processes that constitute the translation mechanism.

4.3 Research Context: Multi-Sector Consulting

The research context of the present study is multi-sector consulting — the professional domain in which consulting practitioners work across industries, organizational types, and functional areas to support digital transformation initiatives. This context is deliberately chosen for its analytical productivity in investigating the research questions. Multi-sector consulting professionals encounter a wide variety of governance architectures, cultural configurations, leadership orientations, and capability conditions across their client engagements, making their accounts particularly rich sources of comparative evidence about the organizational conditions that enable or constrain the analytics-to-execution translation process (Evans, 2017; Davenport & Harris, 2017).

The multi-sector context also enables the study to investigate translation mechanisms across diverse organizational environments without requiring a single-organization case study design that would limit the generalizability of findings to one institutional context. The accounts of consulting practitioners who have worked across life sciences, technology, energy, financial services, and product development sectors reveal the operation of translation mechanisms under varying structural, cultural, political, and resource conditions — providing the empirical variation required to reconstruct mechanisms that are robust across organizational contexts rather than specific to any single industry or institutional setting.

Within this context, consulting professionals are the appropriate unit of observation because they occupy the intermediary position that is analytically central to the research questions. They operate simultaneously within the analytical domain — interpreting data

outputs and constructing strategic recommendations — and within the organizational domain — navigating governance processes, managing political dynamics, and supporting operational implementation. No other organizational role combines these two dimensions of the translation process in the same way or with the same analytical visibility.

4.4 Sampling Strategy and Participant Profile

The study employs a purposeful expert sampling strategy. Participants were selected on the basis of their professional engagement with analytics-driven digital transformation initiatives in consulting-adjacent roles — roles that involve interaction with analytics outputs, organizational decision makers, and execution processes within client organizations. This selection criterion reflects the analytical logic of the study: the research questions can only be investigated through the accounts of professionals who have direct experience with the translation process, and purposeful sampling is the methodological strategy through which such professionals are identified and recruited.

Purposeful expert sampling is distinguished from random sampling by its commitment to information richness over statistical representativeness. The objective is not to recruit a sample that mirrors the demographic or institutional composition of the consulting profession as a whole, but to identify participants whose professional experience provides the analytical depth and organizational complexity required to reconstruct the translation mechanism. The eight participants recruited for this study represent diverse functional specializations — from Big Four strategy consulting through data platform architecture to digital platform development — different levels of organizational seniority, and different sectoral contexts, ensuring that the dataset reflects variation across the principal dimensions of the translation mechanism.

Table 4.1 presents the full participant profile, including each participant's interview identifier, professional role, sector context, seniority level, and primary Sub-Research

Question relevance. The participant profiles establish that the dataset encompasses the analytical depth, sectoral diversity, and functional range required to address the study's research questions.

Table 4.1 Participant Profile and SRQ Relevance

ID	Participant	Role	Sector	Level	Primary SRQ
INT-01	Karana Kumar	Digital Transformation Lead	Life Sciences and Healthcare	Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 2
INT-02	Satish Rajanna	Sales and Demand Generation Lead	Technology and SaaS	Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 4
INT-03	Rohit V. Dev	Strategy and Analytics Consultant	Multi-sector Consulting	Mid-Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 3, SRQ 4
INT-04	Akashdeep	Strategy Consultant, Big Four	Energy and Industrial	Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 3, SRQ 4
INT-05	Allan D'Almeida	Analytics and Digital Strategy Professional	Multi-sector	Mid-Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 3
INT-06	Vivek Vasista	Data and Technology Engineer	Technology and Engineering	Mid	SRQ 1, SRQ 4
INT-07	Sharath Prakash	Digital Platform Developer	Product and Technology	Mid-Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 4
INT-08	Kumar Aswath	Data Platform Architect	Multi-sector Consulting	Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 3

Note. Author's own construction from interview data.

4.5 Data Collection

4.5.1 Interview Design

Data collection was conducted through semi-structured interviews, each lasting approximately forty-five to sixty minutes. The semi-structured format was selected as the most appropriate method for accessing the experiential accounts of consulting professionals about the complex organizational processes they navigate in analytics-to-execution translation. Semi-structured interviews enable the systematic exploration of theoretically defined constructs while preserving the flexibility to pursue inductively emerging themes that may extend or refine the deductive framework. This balance between deductive structure and inductive openness reflects the abductive research logic that governs the study's analytical approach.

The interview guide was organized into seven thematic sections corresponding to the four Sub-Research Questions and the broader analytical concerns of the study. Section 0 established professional background and general orientation; Sections 1 and 2 addressed the translation process and operationalization (SRQ 1); Section 3 addressed organizational constraints (SRQ 2); Section 4 addressed governance architecture (SRQ 3); Sections 5 and 6 addressed political dynamics and cross-sector variation (SRQ 4); and the closing reflection section invited participants to synthesize their professional experience. Questions were presented as thematic prompts with flexibility for follow-up and probing in response to participant accounts. All interviews were recorded with participant consent and subsequently transcribed for analysis.

4.5.2 Ethical Considerations

The study was conducted in accordance with standard ethical requirements for qualitative research involving human participants. All eight participants provided informed consent prior to interview participation, having received a full explanation of the study's purpose, the intended use of interview data, the conditions of data storage and confidentiality, and their right to withdraw from the study at any point without consequence. Interview data were stored securely and accessed only by the researcher. Participants were not asked to disclose confidential client information. Where participants voluntarily disclosed context-specific details that could identify client organizations, those details were generalized or omitted from data presentation to protect client confidentiality.

Participant identities are protected through the use of interview identifiers (INT-01 through INT-08) throughout the study. Participant names appear only in the participant profile table (Table 4.1) and are reproduced with explicit participant consent. The study did not involve any deception, was not conducted with vulnerable populations, and posed no foreseeable risks to participants beyond the minor time commitment involved in interview participation.

4.6 Data Analysis Strategy

4.6.1 Deductive Coding Framework

The data analysis strategy proceeded through seven analytically distinct stages, organized across five subsections below, with Stages 2 through 4 (first-order coding, axial coding, and selective coding) consolidated within Section 4.6.2 as sequential components of a single coding pass. The first stage established the deductive coding framework through a systematic review of the canonical theoretical corpus. Four primary code families were constructed, each corresponding to a Sub-Research Question: Consultant Interpretation and Operationalization (SRQ 1); Structural, Cultural, and Resource-Based Organizational

Constraints (SRQ 2); Governance Architecture and Configuration (SRQ 3); and Political and Cognitive Mediation Dynamics (SRQ 4). Within each code family, sub-codes were defined to capture the specific dimensions of each theoretical construct as operationalized in the interview protocol. Canonical anchors were assigned to each sub-code to maintain explicit links between the deductive coding architecture and the theoretical literature from which constructs were derived.

4.6.2 Coding Stages: From First-Order Concepts to Aggregate Dimensions

The second stage applied the deductive coding framework to the full interview dataset, generating the master coding matrix comprising ninety-seven first-order concepts across all eight interviews. First-order concepts preserve informant language in accordance with the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013), ensuring that the analytical categories derived from the data reflect the experiential vocabulary and conceptual frameworks of the consulting professionals themselves rather than imposing theoretical constructs on their accounts. Each first-order concept was coded with its corresponding Sub-Research Question mapping, establishing the explicit link between informant account and analytical construct.

The third and fourth stages involved axial and selective coding, through which the ninety-seven first-order concepts were systematically clustered into analytically coherent second-order themes and then organized into six aggregate dimensions. The axial coding process identified thirty-three second-order themes, each grouping conceptually related first-order informant terms into a more abstract analytical category. The selective coding process organized these second-order themes into the six aggregate dimensions that constitute the Gioia data structure: Analytics Capability and Infrastructure; Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation; Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation; Decision Authority and Governance Filtering; Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution; and Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics.

4.6.3 Cross-Interview Pattern Validation and Constraint Pre-Classification

The fifth stage involved cross-interview pattern validation, in which the distribution of first-order concepts and second-order themes across all eight interview participants was systematically analyzed to identify patterns of analytical saturation and cross-case consistency. The cross-interview pattern matrix (Appendix I) documents the distribution of thirteen key second-order themes across all eight participants, enabling empirical assessment of whether the analytical dimensions identified in the Gioia data structure reflect dataset-wide patterns rather than idiosyncratic characteristics of individual participant accounts. This validation stage confirmed that the principal dimensions of the translation mechanism — interpretive mediation, governance filtering, political-cognitive mediation, and execution decision authority — are evidenced across multiple participants and sectoral contexts, providing the empirical basis for analytical generalization.

4.6.4 Mechanism Reconstruction

The sixth stage involved mechanism reconstruction, in which the analytically validated second-order themes and aggregate dimensions were synthesized into the seven-stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism documented in Appendix J and refined in Section 6.5 of Chapter 6. Mechanism reconstruction followed the critical realist logic of the study: observable patterns in the interview data were interpreted through the theoretical framework to identify the underlying causal processes — the translation mechanisms — that generate those patterns. The seven stages of the mechanism were derived abductively from the intersection of the deductive theoretical framework and the inductive patterns identified in the Gioia data structure.

4.6.5 Refined Translation Mediation Framework

The seventh and final stage produced the refined Translation Mediation Framework (Appendix K and Table 3.2) through the encounter between the initial conceptual framework

of Chapter 3 and the empirical findings of the mechanism reconstruction stage. The refined framework preserves the seven-stage sequential architecture of the original Translation Model while substantially revising three of its theoretical assumptions in light of the empirical evidence: the nature of governance filtering, the relationship between structural constraints and political-cognitive mediation, and the conceptualization of execution drift. These revisions are developed in full in Chapter 6.

4.7 Trustworthiness and Rigor

The trustworthiness of qualitative research is evaluated through four criteria identified by Lincoln and Guba (1985): credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability. Credibility — the degree to which the research findings accurately represent the experiences and perspectives of participants — is supported in the present study by the use of theoretical saturation as a sampling criterion, by the systematic application of the Gioia methodology as an established qualitative analytical framework, and by the explicit grounding of first-order concepts in informant language rather than researcher-imposed categories. The hybrid abductive approach — combining deductive theoretical anchoring with inductive theme development — further enhances credibility by preventing the imposition of predetermined analytical categories on empirically generated data.

Transferability — the degree to which findings may be applicable to analogous contexts — is addressed through thick description of the research context, participant profiles, and analytical procedures, enabling readers to assess the conditions under which the translation mechanisms identified in this study may operate in comparable consulting-led transformation contexts. Dependability — the degree to which the analytical process is consistent and replicable — is supported by the systematic documentation of all analytical stages in the appendices, including the master coding matrix (Appendix E), axial coding matrix (Appendix F), selective coding structure (Appendix G), cross-interview pattern matrix

(Appendix I), and mechanism reconstruction table (Appendix J). Confirmability — the degree to which findings reflect the data rather than researcher bias — is supported by the explicit mapping of all analytical claims to specific first-order concepts derived from informant accounts, maintained through the Gioia data structure throughout the analysis.

5. EMPIRICAL FINDINGS

5.1 Analytical Strategy and Mechanism Identification

The empirical findings presented in this chapter are organized according to the four Sub-Research Questions that structure the study's analytical architecture and are grounded in the constructs and relationships defined in the conceptual framework of Chapter 3. The six aggregate dimensions of the Gioia data structure — Analytics Capability and Infrastructure, Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation, Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation, Decision Authority and Governance Filtering, Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution, and Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics — map directly onto the Translation Model's seven-stage mechanism, providing the empirical foundation for the mechanism reconstruction developed in Chapter 6. The findings are organised across five subsections, corresponding to the major analytical themes generated through Stage 1 (Insight Generation) and refined through Stages 2–7 of the Translation Mediation Framework.

Table 5.1 presents the full Gioia data structure, comprising the ninety-seven first-order concepts derived from the eight semi-structured interviews, organized into second-order themes and six aggregate dimensions. This three-level analytical structure constitutes the primary analytical output of the Gioia methodology as applied to the dataset and provides the evidentiary foundation for all analytical claims advanced in this chapter. First-order concepts are presented in informant language to preserve the experiential texture of participant accounts; second-order themes represent the researcher's interpretive organization

of conceptually related informant terms; and aggregate dimensions represent the highest level of analytical abstraction, corresponding to the major structural components of the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism.

Table 5.1 Gioia Data Structure — Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism

First-Order Concepts (Informant Terms)	Second-Order Themes	Aggregate Dimensions
Digitalizing manual hiring workflows; Faster hiring through digital workflows; Using data to improve existing processes	Analytics-enabled process automation and improvement	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Organizations increasing analytics use in operations; Analytics capabilities still evolving; Gradual integration of analytics tools	Expansion and adoption of analytics in operational decision processes	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Data teams preparing dashboards and reports; Dedicated analytics team analyzing data; Centralized data teams generating analytics	Centralized analytics capability	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Hybrid analytics structure combining centralized platform and embedded analysts; Different departments managing their own analytics;	Hybrid analytics governance structures	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure

Regional analytics teams
operating independently

Bringing data from
different systems;
Building data platforms
that integrate operational
data; Organizational data
integrated across systems

Data integration across
organizational systems

Analytics Capability and
Infrastructure

KPI thresholds triggering
operational actions;
Measuring analytics
execution through KPI
comparison and testing

Metrics-driven
operational triggers and
measurement of analytics
impact

Analytics Capability and
Infrastructure

Dashboards used to
monitor operational
performance; Leadership
using dashboards to view
data; Dashboards
providing visibility but
execution decided by
business

Dashboard-based
performance monitoring

Analytics Visibility and Insight
Generation

Reviewing analytics
during management
meetings; Presenting
analytics outputs in
executive meetings;
Discussing analytics
results in strategy
meetings

Analytics reviewed in
managerial decision
forums

Analytics Visibility and Insight
Generation

Predictive analytics used
to support strategic
decisions; Predictive and
prescriptive analytics used
for planning decisions;
Predictive forecasting

Analytics informing
strategic decision making

Analytics Visibility and Insight
Generation

influencing strategic
expansion decision

Business teams relying on
analytics reports;
Organizations increasing
analytics use in operations

Dependence on analytics
reporting

Analytics Visibility and Insight
Generation

Consultants interpreting
analytics insights for
leadership teams;
Consultants translating
analytics findings into
business
recommendations;
Consultants acting as
intermediaries between
analytics and business

Consultant mediation of
analytics insights

Consultant-Mediated Insight
Translation

Simplifying analytics
results for business
stakeholders; Explaining
analytics insights in
business terms;
Stakeholders asking
consultants to translate
analytics outputs

Translation of analytics
for business audiences

Consultant-Mediated Insight
Translation

Collaboration between
data teams and business
teams; Cross-functional
analytics teams working
together

Cross-functional analytics
collaboration

Consultant-Mediated Insight
Translation

Business leaders deciding
on execution of analytics
insights; Business owners
responsible for final
execution decisions;
Operational managers

Business authority over
execution decisions

Decision Authority and Governance
Filtering

deciding on analytics
implementation

Governance structures
influencing analytics
initiatives; Governance
processes requiring
multiple management
layers approving analytics
recommendations; Senior
management sign-off on
analytics-driven projects

Governance approval of
analytics initiatives

Decision Authority and Governance
Filtering

Analytics teams initiating
analytics projects;
Analytics capabilities
continuing to develop
with more data; Trying to
build real-time dashboards

Analytics capability
development

Decision Authority and Governance
Filtering

Dashboards providing
visibility but execution
decided by business;
Separation between
analytics visibility and
execution authority

Separation between
analytics visibility and
execution

Decision Authority and Governance
Filtering

Data quality issues in
analytics systems; Legacy
systems still used in
analytics environments;
Manual processes slowing
implementation of
analytics insights

Legacy technology and
operational process
constraints

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

Lack of ownership
preventing execution of
analytics insights; Middle
management risk aversion

Responsibility and
ownership gaps

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

blocking analytics
recommendations

Organizational culture
influencing analytics use;
Organizational culture
influencing acceptance of
analytics insights; Sector
culture influencing
analytics adoption and
execution

Cultural constraints on
analytics adoption

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

Insight overload reducing
action on analytics
signals; Too many alerts
or dashboards reducing
engagement with analytics
outputs

Information overload in
analytics environments

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

Business leaders
reviewing analytics
insights before
implementation; Multiple
management layers
approving analytics
recommendations

Multi-layer governance
approval requirements

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

Operational teams
adapting analytics
recommendations;
Operational teams
deciding how to
implement analytics
recommendations; Some
analytics insights
modified during
implementation

Operational adaptation of
analytics insights

Organizational Constraints on
Analytics Execution

Leaders relying on
experience when analytics

Leadership judgment
overriding analytics

Political–Cognitive Mediation of
Analytics

conflicts with strategy;
 Leaders relying on
 experience when analytics
 conflicts with established
 practice

Stakeholders questioning
 analytics insights that
 challenge experience;
 Leaders skeptical of
 analytics outputs when
 they conflict with
 established assumptions

Leadership skepticism
 toward analytics

Political–Cognitive Mediation of
 Analytics

Informal influence
 affecting analytics
 execution decisions;
 Informal networks and
 relationships shaping
 which analytics
 recommendations receive
 organizational support

Informal political
 influence in decision
 processes

Political–Cognitive Mediation of
 Analytics

Cultural norms selectively
 filtering analytics
 adoption; Selective
 adoption of analytics
 insights that align with
 existing beliefs

Cultural norms selectively
 filtering analytics
 adoption

Political–Cognitive Mediation of
 Analytics

Note. Author's own construction from interview data (INT-01 through INT-08).

5.2 Consultant Interpretation and Framing of Analytics Insights

This section addresses SRQ 1: How do consulting professionals interpret, frame, and operationalize analytics-driven insights during the execution phase of digital transformation initiatives? Across all eight interviews, participants described a consistent pattern of active

interpretive and communicative work through which analytical outputs were converted from technically generated findings into organizationally actionable strategic recommendations.

This interpretive function was not peripheral to consulting work; it was identified as the central professional activity that distinguishes effective analytics-driven consulting from data delivery without organizational impact.

5.2.1 From Data to Strategic Narrative: The Interpretive Function

Participants consistently described the interpretive work of translating analytical outputs as a process of calibrating technical findings to the strategic language and cognitive frameworks of organizational decision makers. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03), a multi-sector strategy and analytics consultant, articulated this interpretive process through a detailed empirical case involving a mid-sized retail client where predictive demand forecasting directly altered an approved expansion strategy. The analytical team had constructed a predictive model integrating historical sales data, e-commerce trends, and competitor activity, which revealed that projected sales growth in the target region reached only 8% against an anticipated 25%, yielding a negative ROI over three years owing to low footfall conversion and high fixed cost. The interpretive challenge in this case was not the generation of the predictive model but the translation of its findings into a strategic argument compelling enough to override an already-approved five-store expansion plan.

The recommendation succeeded because it was framed not as a technical refutation of prior decision-making but as an analytically grounded argument for capital reallocation that ultimately preserved \$8 million to \$10 million in client capital expenditure. This framing function — presenting analytically generated findings as strategic opportunity rather than organizational criticism — emerged as a near-universal principle of effective insight translation across the dataset. Akashdeep (INT-04), a Big Four strategy consultant working across energy and industrial sectors, articulated this principle with explicit clarity:

If you're talking about a consultant presenting those insights, it should not be like a criticism to the company — hey, you're not doing this right — but more like, oh, you can do this better. Framing it as an opportunity rather than a criticism is a better way to go forward to convincing stakeholders. (INT-04)

This orientation — converting empirical analytical evidence into a form of institutional argument positively directed toward the decision maker's strategic interests — represents the first mechanism of the consultant translation process. The Gioia data structure identifies this as 'consultant mediation of analytics insights' within the Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation dimension, consolidating six distinct first-order informant terms into a single second-order theme that captures the interpretive intermediary role of the consulting professional.

5.2.2 Audience Calibration and Staged Communication

A second dimension of interpretive work identified across the dataset concerns the calibration of analytical communication to the specific cognitive frameworks, institutional roles, and decision-making priorities of different organizational audiences. Karana Kumar (INT-01), a digital transformation lead in the life sciences sector, described an iterative, audience-sensitive communication approach in which analytical insights were presented incrementally through proof-of-concept demonstrations and agile milestone checkpoints rather than as finished analytical conclusions:

We always try to show the POC or show the feasibility of the requirement — this is what can be achieved or this is the limitation kind of thing. And then it's been built piece by piece. We have checkpoints that help us to mitigate if there is any misinterpretation. (INT-01)

This staged communication approach reflects a recognition that non-technical organizational audiences — business leaders, department heads, clinical directors — process

analytical recommendations differently than analytically trained professionals, and that iterative demonstration reduces the cognitive distance between analytical output and organizational understanding. The Gioia data structure encodes this as 'translation of analytics for business audiences,' a second-order theme consolidating three first-order concepts relating to simplification, explanation in business terms, and audience requests for consultant mediation. Kumar Aswath (INT-08), a data platform architect working across enterprise analytics deployments, reinforced this from the technical implementation perspective: the recommendation cannot be acted upon if the organizational systems required to capture, manage, and process the underlying data are not themselves operational, a condition that necessitates sequenced, infrastructure-first communication strategies before analytical outputs can be meaningfully presented to governance bodies.

5.2.3 Operationalization: From Approved Insight to Execution Action

Participants described operationalization — the practical conversion of an approved analytical recommendation into a coordinated sequence of organizational actions — as a multi-stage process involving team coordination, sprint-based implementation planning, and adaptive refinement of recommendations in response to operational constraints. Allan D'Almeida (INT-05), a multi-sector analytics and digital strategy professional with extensive IoT implementation experience, provided the most granular account of operationalization timelines:

If you are already in the process of transformation and you identify some insights, these are much quicker to implement — it might take three months — because you have the foundation layer built. The main foundation from scratch to the end, it might take 18 months. (INT-05)

This distinction between foundational and incremental operationalization is analytically significant. It establishes that the translation timeline is not intrinsic to the quality

of the analytical insight but is a function of the pre-existing infrastructure and organizational readiness conditions that define the execution environment. The Gioia data structure captures this through the 'analytics capability development' and 'organizational adoption of analytics tools' second-order themes within the Analytics Capability and Infrastructure dimension, which together trace the institutional conditions that determine whether operationalization is rapid or protracted.

Satish Rajanna (INT-02), a sales and demand generation lead in the technology sector, articulated a revenue-linked operationalization rationale that reflects the commercial priorities of SaaS consulting environments. Execution priority is assigned to those analytical findings whose anticipated return most clearly exceeds the investment required to pursue them — a heuristic in which market addressable revenue projections determine which insights are operationalized first. This prioritization dimension of the translation process — the consultant's selection of which insights to advance, and in what order — represents an undertheorized dimension of the translation role that emerges clearly from the dataset.

5.2.4 The Four-Stage Translation Sequence

Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) synthesized the operationalization process into an analytically productive four-stage sequence that corresponds closely to the Translation Mediation Framework's staged architecture:

I would say the first phase would be interpretation. The second phase would be the decision. The third phase we generally execute — that's the execution stage. And the last stage would be measurement. These are the four important stages that we generally go through. (INT-03)

This practitioner-validated sequence — interpret, decide, execute, measure — constitutes the operational micro-logic of the translation mechanism as experienced by consulting professionals. It maps directly onto the Translation Model's Stages 2 through 7,

confirming that the conceptual framework's sequential architecture reflects the experiential structure of the translation process as practitioners enact it. The sequence resonates with Kaplan and Norton's (2008) performance management cycle, in which strategic priorities are translated through successive operationalization stages into measurable execution outcomes, and with Davenport and Harris's (2017) analytics-to-decision pathway, in which analytical outputs must pass through interpretation and organizational decision-making before reaching execution. The empirical emergence of this four-stage sequence from practitioner accounts thus provides independent, interview-grounded validation of the theoretical logic embedded in both the canonical corpus and the Translation Model.

5.3 Organizational Constraint Configurations

This section addresses SRQ 2: What structural, cultural, political, and capability-related constraints shape whether and how analytics-driven insights inform execution-level strategic decisions? Across the dataset, four categories of organizational constraint were identified with consistent empirical support: structural and governance constraints; resource and capability constraints; accountability and incentive constraints; and cultural constraints. These four categories correspond to the Organizational Constraint Typology developed in Chapter 3, and their empirical configurations across the participant dataset reveal distinct patterns of constraint interaction that shape translation outcomes.

5.3.1 Structural and Governance Constraints

Structural constraints — governance hierarchies, approval processes, regulatory requirements, and functional boundaries — were identified by every participant as conditions that shape the speed, scope, and directional outcomes of the analytics-to-execution translation process. The most consistently identified structural constraint is the multi-level approval architecture through which analytics-driven recommendations must pass before reaching execution. Akashdeep (INT-04) described the governance architecture of his client

engagements with particular specificity: following analytical validation, recommendations advance to board-level review where the topic owner, if the recommendation is approved, receives budget authorization to execute the project. The Gioia data structure captures this through the 'governance approval of analytics initiatives' second-order theme within the Decision Authority and Governance Filtering dimension, which consolidates five distinct first-order informant terms relating to governance committee approvals, multiple management layers, senior management sign-off, multiple approval sequences, and governance structures influencing initiative selection.

The governance filtering mechanism operates not merely as a bureaucratic formality but as a substantive evaluative process in which the strategic relevance, financial viability, and political acceptability of an analytical recommendation are assessed by actors with formal decision authority. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) articulated the sequential logic of governance change, identifying that KPIs change first, then workflows update within one to three months, with governance frameworks formalizing over three to six months — a temporal sequencing that has direct implications for translation speed. Analytics-driven recommendations that require governance restructuring to be implementable will face longer translation delays than recommendations that can be executed within existing governance parameters.

Functional silos emerged as a second major category of structural constraint. Allan D'Almeida (INT-05) identified silo-based fragmentation as the root cause of most analytics execution failures, citing lack of free-flowing communication and absence of interdependency monitoring as the primary mechanisms through which siloed working prevents analytics-informed coordination across organizational units. Sharath Prakash (INT-07) provided a granular account of how cross-functional technical barriers — specifically the incompatibility between legacy PHP systems and RESTful APIs used by newer teams —

create structural obstacles that require dedicated bridge functions to overcome. The Gioia data structure captures these structural realities through the 'legacy technology and operational process constraints' second-order theme within the Organizational Constraints dimension. Regulatory and compliance constraints constitute a further structural barrier operating with particular intensity in regulated sectors: Vivek Vasista (INT-06), working in safety-critical engineering contexts in Germany, identified GDPR compliance and ethics requirements as primary structural conditions that must be satisfied before any analytics deployment can be operationalized.

5.3.2 Resource and Capability Constraints

Budget constraints emerged as the most consistently cited resource-based constraint across the dataset, identified by participants across all sectoral contexts as a primary mechanism through which analytics-driven recommendations fail to achieve execution. Akashdeep (INT-04) ranked insufficient investment capacity as the leading barrier to analytics execution: organizations may possess the analytical capability to generate actionable insights but lack the financial authority to fund the organizational changes those insights require. Satish Rajanna (INT-02) corroborated this observation:

If the budget and time is not there, obviously those are the ones because the team comes with very fancy initiatives and the analytics says that the customers whom you are planning to take — it's going to give you a long-term return, not a short-term return. (INT-02)

This short-term versus long-term budget tension — in which analytics-driven recommendations that promise long-term strategic value are systematically deprioritized in favor of initiatives with demonstrable short-term financial returns — represents a structural resource constraint with significant implications for the types of analytical insights that achieve execution. Long-term value analytics, including predictive capability investments,

platform transformation projects, and cultural change programs, are disproportionately vulnerable to budget-based execution failure because their returns are not captured within the annual financial planning cycles that govern resource allocation decisions. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) identified a related resource dynamic: the lock-in of funds in annual planning cycles prevents rapid reallocation in response to analytically generated insights, with approximately 40% of potential execution actions failing because funds are already committed to existing contracts and operational budgets.

5.3.3 Accountability and Incentive Constraints

Across the dataset, the absence of clear ownership of analytics-driven recommendations — the failure to assign explicit accountability for translating specific insights into specific actions — emerged as a critical execution constraint that operates independently of structural and resource conditions. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) identified unclear ownership as the first of the three primary barriers to analytics execution, alongside manual process dependencies and silo-based fragmentation — all three of which he characterized as fixable with defined owners, automation, and cross-functional coordination. The Gioia data structure encodes this as the 'responsibility and ownership gaps' second-order theme within the Organizational Constraints dimension.

Sometimes the middle management or the project managers — they may be risk averse because they are in new senior leadership positions and would not want to take on topics that they are not confident about themselves. (INT-04)

This risk aversion dynamic — in which middle management actors suppress analytically supported recommendations not through skepticism of the evidence but through personal accountability calculus — corresponds directly to the 'responsibility and ownership gaps' second-order theme in the Gioia data structure. The mechanism is not structural in origin but is structurally produced: the absence of explicit accountability frameworks creates

the organizational conditions in which individual risk aversion becomes the de facto governance filter for analytics-driven action. Across SRQ 2, accountability and incentive constraints therefore represent a distinct constraint category whose resolution requires organizational design intervention — specifically, the explicit assignment of named ownership over analytics-driven recommendations throughout the translation pathway.

5.3.4 Cultural Constraints and Sector Variation

Cultural constraints — the tacit assumptions, dominant cognitive frames, and institutionalized norms that condition how organizational actors perceive and respond to analytics-driven recommendations — emerged as both a category of structural constraint (SRQ 2) and a dimension of actor-level mediation (SRQ 4). In the context of SRQ 2, cultural constraints are treated as structural conditions that preexist and condition the translation process without requiring specific actor intent. The Gioia data structure encodes this through the 'cultural constraints on analytics adoption' second-order theme, which consolidates three first-order concepts relating to organizational culture influencing analytics use, organizational culture influencing acceptance of analytics insights, and sector culture influencing analytics adoption and execution.

Karana Kumar (INT-01) identified culture — rather than governance structure — as the primary source of organizational variation in analytics-driven transformation contexts, noting that the organization's cultural relationship to digital innovation shapes how analytical recommendations are received before any formal governance process engages with them. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) extended this to a cross-sectoral comparison: retail and technology sectors, characterized by experimental cultures and fast feedback cycles, achieve substantially higher analytics-to-execution translation rates than manufacturing and public sector organizations, where cultural resistance and legacy system dependencies produce chronic execution lags. Akashdeep (INT-04) echoed this sectoral differentiation, noting that

technology-native and software-native companies are fast in both translating insights and executing them, while industrial and energy sector clients face both structural regulatory constraints and cultural risk aversion that simultaneously slow and narrow the scope of analytics influence.

5.4 Governance Dynamics: Centralization vs. Decentralization

This section addresses SRQ 3: How does the centralization or decentralization of analytics capabilities affect decision authority, execution speed, and strategic alignment during digital transformation initiatives? The governance configuration question — centralized, decentralized, or hybrid — proved to be one of the most empirically generative topics in the interview dataset, with participants offering detailed, experience-based accounts of how governance architecture shapes the translation mechanism.

5.4.1 The Dominant Pattern: Hybrid Architecture

The most consistent finding across the dataset is that hybrid analytics governance models — characterized by centralized data platform ownership and governance standards combined with decentralized business-unit-level execution and domain-specific analysis — represent the dominant observed configuration in client organizations and the preferred model recommended by most participants. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) provided the most analytically detailed account of the hybrid model's operational logic:

Most of the client organizations work with hybrid — which is hub and spoke or federated analytics model — even if they started purely with centralized or decentralized. The centralized team owns data platforms, governance and core models, while embedded analytics analysts in business units handle domain-specific reporting and use cases. (INT-03)

This hub-and-spoke configuration achieves a structural balance that neither purely centralized nor purely decentralized models can replicate: centralized ownership of data

quality standards, core predictive models, and governance frameworks ensures consistency and reliability of analytical outputs, while decentralized business-unit-level embedded analysts ensure that those outputs are interpreted and deployed with contextual knowledge of the specific operational environments in which execution decisions are made. The Gioia data structure encodes this configuration through the 'hybrid analytics governance structures' second-order theme within the Analytics Capability and Infrastructure dimension. Akashdeep (INT-04) corroborated this configuration through reference to a centralized data infrastructure and modeling capability combined with territory-level and business-unit-level execution — precisely the configuration that the hub-and-spoke model describes. The convergence of this reference architecture across multiple interview contexts, without prompting, suggests that the hybrid hub-and-spoke model has achieved sufficient institutional currency in the consulting community to function as a de facto governance standard.

5.4.2 Centralization: Standardization at the Cost of Speed

Participants described centralized analytics governance as providing significant advantages in data quality, governance standardization, and strategic alignment — at the cost of execution speed and organizational responsiveness. Akashdeep (INT-04) characterized centralization as a double-edged structural arrangement:

In a centralized process, approval can be slower, but it is standardized. So yes, eventually it will get approved — but it is a slower process because there is a group of systems that will make those decisions, and it's not only your topic that the centralized department is working on. They have many other topics.

So it takes time for them to prioritize. (INT-04)

5.4.3 Decentralization: Speed at the Cost of Alignment

Decentralized analytics governance was consistently characterized as producing faster execution at the level of individual business units or project teams, but at significant risk of

misalignment, data inconsistency, and duplicated analytical effort. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) provided the most analytically precise account of decentralization's trade-off profile:

Decentralized creates the worst bottlenecks — each team builds their own pipeline, which is three times the data cost, with conflicting churn definitions across marketing and sales. Centralized ensures quality; embedded teams provide speed and context. (INT-03)

5.4.4 Governance Configuration and Sector-Specific Constraints

Satish Rajanna (INT-02) introduced a sector-specificity dimension to the governance configuration debate: the optimal governance model is not universal but is contingent on the organizational context, the volume and variability of data, and the regulatory environment in which the organization operates. For FMCG organizations with high data volume and relatively stable product categories, centralized governance is the most efficient model because cross-market data patterns are directly comparable and strategically generalizable. For technology subscription businesses operating in compliance-heavy regulatory environments, decentralized governance is more effective because regional regulatory variation makes centralized data standards difficult to maintain.

5.4.5 Governance Configuration and Decision Authority

The relationship between governance configuration and decision authority emerged as a particularly consequential dimension of the translation mechanism. In centralized governance models, decision authority over analytics-driven recommendations rests at the top of the organizational hierarchy — with boards, CFOs, CEOs, and senior executive committees — meaning that the translation mechanism must traverse the full organizational hierarchy before an execution decision can be reached. In decentralized models, decision authority is delegated to business unit leads, product owners, and metric owners, enabling faster analytics-to-execution translation but potentially producing execution decisions that are

misaligned with organizational-level strategic priorities. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) articulated the authority allocation logic with particular clarity:

It always goes back to the business owner, or maybe it could be a metric owner. They generally have the decision power in that particular moment, because the person accountable for KPIs or business outcomes doesn't usually fall under the data team or analyst team. Analytics supports rather than replaces business judgment. (INT-03)

This observation captures a fundamental structural feature of the translation mechanism: the institutional authority to execute analytics-driven recommendations resides not in the analytical function but in the business domain that analytics serves. The translation mechanism is therefore inherently dependent on the alignment between what analytics recommends and what business owners are willing and able to execute within their authority boundaries.

5.5 Political and Cognitive Mediation Processes

This section addresses SRQ 4: How do tacit assumptions, cognitive frames, leadership orientations, and political dynamics mediate the acceptance, adaptation, or resistance to analytics-driven recommendations during strategy execution? The findings presented here are analytically distinct from the structural constraints of SRQ 2 in that they focus on the specific interpretive, political, and relational activities of identifiable organizational actors — leaders, managers, informal networks, and consulting professionals — rather than the structural conditions within which those actors operate.

5.5.1 Leadership Cognitive Framing of Analytics

Leadership orientation toward analytics-driven evidence emerged across the dataset as one of the most powerful single mediating variables in the translation mechanism.

Participants consistently identified leadership commitment to data-driven decision-making as

a necessary condition — though not a sufficient one — for effective analytics-to-execution translation. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) articulated the leadership mediation mechanism in terms of three interconnected leadership functions: priority-setting, resource allocation, and accountability enforcement:

Leadership behavior always influences analytics translation to execution by setting priorities or modeling data-driven decisions, allocating resources, or enforcing accountability for acting on insights. Leadership shapes execution by organizing data culture, modeling insight use, funding all those enablers, and holding teams accountable — turning analytics from nice-to-have reports into business mandates. (INT-03)

The framing of analytics as either a 'nice-to-have report' or a 'business mandate' directly reflects the cognitive frame through which leadership mediates the organizational value assigned to analytical evidence. Akashdeep (INT-04) provided a nuanced account of the variation in leadership cognitive frames, identifying a spectrum that ranges from leaders who treat analytical insights as merely advisory to leaders who actively champion analytics-driven recommendations through governance processes. Critically, he identified politically cautious leaders as a distinct category whose mediation is shaped not primarily by cognitive skepticism of analytical evidence but by political calculation about the consequences of advancing transformative recommendations:

A topic can be useful for the company, but very difficult to execute. So the politically cautious leader will eventually not push those topics because it may be uncomfortable for him to execute on it. (INT-04)

This finding — that leadership mediation of analytics-driven recommendations is shaped by political risk calculation as well as analytical judgment — extends the theoretical account of leadership as a primarily cognitive mediator and establishes a hybrid category in

which cognitive openness to analytical evidence is paired with political reluctance to champion the organizational disruptions that evidence-based recommendations may require.

5.5.2 Informal Power Structures and Relational Networks

Informal power structures — the networks of trusted relationships, advisory authority, and interpersonal influence that exist alongside and often override formal organizational hierarchies — were identified across the dataset as significant mediating conditions that shape whether analytics-driven recommendations reach formal governance review and, if they do, how they are received. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) provided the most analytically complete account of informal power's translation effects:

Execution decisions are always through the relationship networks with all the trusted influences and cultural norms that often override formal analytics processes or hierarchies. Informal power works through trusted advisors — unofficial go-to people whose opinions sway decisions more than the data.

Sometimes it could be a relationship network: my buddy is also working in the ops team, so let's go ahead and take a look at what he says about it. (INT-03)

This relational dimension of the translation mechanism operates at the pre-governance stage: informal conversations and peer-to-peer advocacy among trusted organizational actors condition the reception of analytics-driven recommendations before they enter formal governance processes. Consulting professionals who understand and engage with these informal influence networks can accelerate analytics-to-execution translation by building informal coalitions of support before formal governance review. Akashdeep (INT-04) elaborated this consulting-level implication through a specific observation about the sequencing of stakeholder engagement: effective analytics translation requires identifying internal champions — organizational actors whose interests are served by the

recommendation and who possess the informal influence to build internal support — before approaching formal governance bodies.

Allan D'Almeida (INT-05) characterized informal influence as operating fundamentally through interpersonal soft skills — the capacity to negotiate, build relational trust, and communicate with clarity about expectations and boundaries — and identified this relational work as a daily professional reality that shapes which analytical recommendations gain organizational traction and which stall at the point of interpersonal resistance. Sharath Prakash (INT-07) documented the suppressive dimension of informal power in product development contexts: when senior engineers leverage informal authority to override technically and analytically superior proposals from junior colleagues, the effect is not merely interpersonal but organizational — evidence-based recommendations are suppressed before they can enter formal decision channels. Kumar Aswath (INT-08) reinforced the dataset-wide pattern by distinguishing between the formal organizational structure and the informal relational substrate through which execution decisions are actually accelerated.

5.5.3 Cultural Assumptions and Selective Adoption

Cultural assumptions — the tacit organizational beliefs about how decisions should be made, what types of evidence are credible, and which organizational actors have legitimate analytical authority — emerged as a significant micro-level mediating condition that shapes not only whether analytics-driven recommendations are accepted but which aspects of those recommendations are selectively adopted. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) described the characteristic pattern of stakeholder response to analytics recommendations that challenge established organizational practice:

Stakeholders typically react with initial defensiveness — they usually question data quality or methods — followed by rationalization, because they generally have the prioritizing gut feel and so forth. And then it could be selective

adoptions only when insights align with existing beliefs or show clear short-term wins. (INT-03)

This three-stage pattern — defensiveness, rationalization, selective adoption — represents a micro-level mediation mechanism through which cultural norms protecting established organizational practice filter the analytics-to-execution translation process. The 'selective adoption' stage is particularly analytically significant: it describes a condition in which the formal translation mechanism appears to succeed — the recommendation is adopted — while the substantive content of the recommendation is systematically distorted in the direction of existing organizational practice. Analytics-driven transformation in this context produces incremental adjustment rather than strategic reorientation, because the cultural mediation mechanism ensures that only those dimensions of an analytical recommendation compatible with existing organizational beliefs enter the execution process.

Sharath Prakash (INT-07) provided a direct account of political override: a case in which leadership preference for a specific technological approach — JavaScript/TypeScript rather than the analytically superior Python — persisted despite technical evidence of Python's performance advantages. This instance of political override represents the most direct form of cognitive-political mediation: where organizational authority is deployed to override analytical evidence in favor of institutionally preferred practices.

5.5.4 Trust, Alert Fatigue, and Behavioral Adoption

A dimension of political-cognitive mediation that emerged inductively from the dataset concerns the gap between analytical visibility and behavioral change — the condition in which organizational actors receive analytical outputs and acknowledge their implications but do not change their behavior accordingly. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) identified alert fatigue as a specific manifestation of the gap between analytical visibility and behavioral action:

Teams might ignore 60 to 80 percent of threshold breaches, which reveals low trust or poor integration. The ultimate test of whether analytics has truly changed behavior or not — action rates on operational alerts most resist change, signaling trust or integration gaps. (INT-03)

Alert fatigue represents a failure of the behavioral adoption stage of the translation mechanism: analytics systems generate outputs that are technically accessible to decision makers but are systematically ignored because the volume of alerts exceeds organizational attention capacity, because the recommendations generated by alerts are not credible to the actors who receive them, or because acting on alerts requires workflow changes that organizational culture resists. This finding reveals a dimension of the analytics-to-execution gap that operates not at the governance or political level but at the level of individual actor behavior and organizational habit — the micro-level behavioral conditions through which even technically well-designed and politically endorsed analytics systems fail to produce consistent execution.

5.6 Cross-Theme Mechanisms and Execution Breakdown Dynamics

5.6.1 Recurring Mechanism Sequences

Analysis of the full interview dataset reveals three recurring mechanism sequences through which the analytics-to-execution translation process succeeds or fails. The first sequence — the Framing-Coalition-Governance sequence — characterizes successful translation in organizationally complex client environments: the consultant interprets and frames the analytical recommendation in terms that resonate with key leadership stakeholders; builds an informal coalition of internal champions before formal governance review; and designs the governance presentation to satisfy the evaluative criteria of the relevant approval body. This sequence was described, with variation in emphasis and terminology, by Akashdeep (INT-04), Rohit V. Dev (INT-03), and Satish Rajanna (INT-02),

and represents the dominant model of effective consulting-mediated analytics translation. The Gioia data structure maps each component of this sequence to distinct second-order themes: 'consultant mediation of analytics insights' encodes the framing stage; 'informal political influence in decision processes' encodes the coalition stage; 'governance approval of analytics initiatives' encodes the governance stage.

The second sequence — the Threshold-Trigger-Action sequence — characterizes operational-level analytics execution in organizations with mature data infrastructure and embedded analytics capabilities: a KPI threshold breach triggers an automated notification to the accountable metric owner; the metric owner evaluates the breach against predefined response playbooks; and an execution action is initiated without requiring full governance review. Rohit V. Dev (INT-03) described this as the 'go-no-go trigger' mechanism that enables sub-one-day execution timelines for operational insights when automation and metric ownership are correctly aligned.

The third sequence — the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence — characterizes the most common mode of analytics execution failure across the dataset: an analytically well-supported recommendation is generated but encounters a budget constraint or budget-cycle timing mismatch that prevents resource allocation; the recommendation is deferred to the next planning cycle; the organizational context changes between cycles; and the recommendation loses its strategic relevance before it can be resourced. Multiple participants identified this sequence as the primary mechanism through which analytics-driven recommendations fail to achieve execution — not because of technical inadequacy or political opposition but because of the structural incompatibility between the timing of analytical insight generation and the rigidity of organizational resource allocation cycles.

5.6.2 Points of Execution Drift

Execution drift — the progressive modification of analytics-driven recommendations as they traverse the translation mechanism, such that the recommendation that reaches execution differs substantially from the recommendation generated by the analytical process — emerged as a consistent cross-theme finding. Three primary points of execution drift were identified across the dataset. The first occurs at the interpretive framing stage: when consultants calibrate analytical recommendations to the strategic language and institutional priorities of client organizations, some analytical content is inevitably simplified, compressed, or de-emphasized to make the recommendation organizationally legible. The second point of drift occurs at the governance filtering stage: steering committee evaluations of analytics-driven recommendations frequently result in modifications that reflect the budgetary, political, and strategic priorities of governance participants rather than the analytical logic of the original recommendation. Akashdeep (INT-04) described a case in which leadership's short-term financial risk aversion led to the rejection of an analytically supported early-investment strategy in favor of a more conservative incremental approach. The third point of drift occurs at the operational adaptation stage: implementation teams frequently modify analytics-driven recommendations in response to workflow constraints, resource limitations, and technical incompatibilities encountered during execution.

5.6.3 Emergent Tensions

Three analytical tensions emerged from the cross-theme analysis that extend beyond the individual SRQ domains and condition the overall dynamics of the translation mechanism. The first is the interpretive accessibility versus analytical integrity tension: the more effectively a consulting professional calibrates an analytical recommendation to the cognitive frameworks of a non-technical audience, the greater the risk that analytically critical dimensions of the recommendation are simplified away in the service of

organizational legibility. The second is the governance speed versus strategic alignment tension: governance architectures that enable rapid execution decisions — decentralized models with delegated decision authority — do so at the cost of the strategic alignment that centralized governance provides, while centralized governance produces alignment at the cost of execution speed. The third is the analytics authority versus organizational authority tension: analytical evidence may establish what an organization should do with high technical confidence, but the authority to act remains vested in business domain owners whose decision calculus includes political, cultural, and resource considerations that analytical evidence does not resolve.

6. DISCUSSION

6.1 Revisiting the Research Questions

The discussion chapter situates the empirical findings of Chapter 5 within the canonical theoretical framework established in Chapter 2, develops the theoretical contributions identified in Chapter 3, and presents the refined Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model that constitutes the primary theoretical output of the study. The chapter proceeds through three analytical dimensions — structural and governance reinterpretation, cultural and cognitive mediation, and political filtering and power dynamics — before presenting the refined framework and articulating the four theoretical contributions that the study advances.

The central research question — How do consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints? — is answered through the mechanism-level account developed across the empirical findings and refined in Section 6.5. The answer is not a prescriptive formula but a mechanism-centered description of the organizational conditions

and agentive processes through which translation succeeds or fails. The following sections develop the theoretical dimensions of this answer through systematic engagement with the canonical corpus and the empirical evidence.

6.2 Structural and Governance Reinterpretation

6.2.1 Governance as Sequential Filtering, Not Parallel Processing

The empirical evidence substantially revises the conceptualization of governance filtering developed in Chapter 3. The original Translation Model treated governance mediation — Stage 3 of the seven-stage sequence — as a discrete organizational process in which analytics-driven recommendations are evaluated by governance structures against strategic, financial, and political criteria before receiving execution approval. The empirical findings require a more complex model: governance filtering in practice operates as a sequential multi-layer filtration process in which each governance layer (analytical validation, strategic fit assessment, budget authorization, board-level approval) applies distinct evaluative criteria that operate cumulatively on the recommendation under review.

This finding has direct implications for the Kaplan and Norton (2008) execution premium framework. Kaplan and Norton conceptualize the strategy management process as a coordinated set of management cycles — strategy development, strategy translation, organizational alignment, operational planning, monitoring and learning — that operate in a coherent, well-governed organizational system. The empirical evidence suggests that in the consulting-led digital transformation contexts that participants describe, these cycles frequently operate as independent governance filters rather than coordinated components of a unified execution system. Analytics-driven recommendations must sequentially satisfy each filter's evaluative criteria, and the probability of failure increases with each governance layer traversed.

6.2.2 The Hybrid Governance Convergence

The empirical convergence on hybrid hub-and-spoke governance models as both the dominant observed configuration and the preferred theoretical model represents a significant empirical finding that extends the existing literature on analytics governance architecture. Davenport and Harris (2017) discuss the organizational conditions required for analytics maturity without prescribing a specific governance architecture; Evans (2017) addresses governance architecture as a structural enabling condition without identifying the hybrid model as a convergent preference across organizational contexts. The present study's empirical finding that consulting professionals across multiple sectors and seniority levels independently recommend the hub-and-spoke configuration suggests that this architecture has emerged as a practical solution to the governance trade-off between standardization and agility that the purely centralized and purely decentralized models cannot resolve.

6.2.3 Structural Constraint Configurations and Execution Failure

The empirical identification of the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence as the most common mode of analytics execution failure across the dataset represents a theoretical extension of the strategy execution literature's account of resource allocation failures. Kaplan and Norton (2008) address the strategy-operations budgeting interface through the STRATEX concept — dedicated funding streams for strategic initiatives that are explicitly separated from operational budgets. The empirical evidence suggests that STRATEX-type mechanisms are rarely operative in the client organizations that participants describe: analytics-driven recommendations most commonly compete for funding within fixed annual budget cycles that are designed around historical operational patterns rather than dynamic analytical insight outputs.

The Budget-Lock-Drift sequence represents a structurally produced translation failure that is distinct from both political opposition and capability inadequacy: organizations may

possess the analytical capability to generate sound recommendations and the political will to pursue them, yet systematically fail to translate them into execution because the timing of insight generation is incompatible with the rigidity of resource allocation cycles. This structural incompatibility is not addressed by the existing canonical frameworks, which tend to treat resource allocation as a governance design challenge rather than a structural temporal constraint on analytics-to-execution translation.

6.3 Cultural and Cognitive Mediation

6.3.1 The Analytics–Culture Gap as a Structural Condition

The empirical findings substantially develop Schein and Schein's (2016) account of organizational culture as a constraint on analytics adoption by establishing that cultural constraints operate at multiple levels of the translation mechanism simultaneously — as structural background conditions that preexist and condition the translation process (SRQ 2) and as specific actor-level mediation processes enacted by identifiable organizational members (SRQ 4). This dual operation of cultural constraints — as structural conditions and as enacted mediation — represents a theoretical refinement of the existing literature, which tends to treat culture either as a structural background condition or as a dimension of individual actor behavior without theorizing the interaction between these two levels.

6.3.2 Leadership Cognitive Frames as Mediating Conditions

The identification of politically cautious leaders as a distinct category of cognitive-political mediator represents a theoretical extension of Schein and Schein's (2016) account of leadership culture. Schein and Schein characterize organizational culture as shaped by leadership behavior and particularly by the assumptions and values that leaders embed in organizational processes through their decisions, communications, and behavioral modeling. The empirical finding that leadership mediation of analytics-driven recommendations is shaped not only by cognitive orientations toward analytical evidence but by political risk

calculations about the organizational consequences of championing transformative recommendations introduces a political dimension to the leadership-culture relationship that Schein and Schein's framework does not fully capture.

6.3.3 Alert Fatigue and the Behavioral Adoption Gap

The alert fatigue finding — that teams systematically ignore between sixty and eighty percent of analytically generated threshold breach notifications — reveals a dimension of the analytics-to-execution gap that is not addressed by any of the canonical frameworks. Davenport and Harris (2017) address analytics adoption as a function of organizational maturity and leadership commitment; Kaplan and Norton (2008) address performance monitoring as a governance process for tracking execution outcomes. Neither framework theorizes the micro-level behavioral condition in which technically accessible and organizationally endorsed analytical outputs are systematically ignored by the individual actors whose behavior they are designed to influence. The alert fatigue finding establishes that the analytics-to-execution gap persists into the behavioral adoption stage — after governance approval, after political negotiation, after operational planning — revealing a behavioral last mile that existing frameworks have not theorized and that constitutes a critical dimension of the translation mechanism.

6.4 Political Filtering and Power Dynamics

6.4.1 The Power School Revisited in Analytics Contexts

The empirical findings provide substantial support for Mintzberg et al.'s (1998) Power School account of strategy formation as a political process, while extending its application to the analytics-to-execution translation context. The Power School characterizes strategy formation as a process of bargaining, negotiation, and coalition-building through which competing organizational interests are accommodated and reconciled — a characterization that the empirical evidence confirms applies with full force to the governance processes

through which analytics-driven recommendations are evaluated and approved. Analytics-driven recommendations do not succeed by virtue of their analytical quality alone; they succeed when consulting professionals navigate the political landscape of client organizations effectively enough to build sufficient organizational support to survive the governance process.

6.4.2 Informal Networks as Translation Accelerators and Blockers

The empirical evidence substantially develops the theoretical account of informal power structures as mediating conditions in the analytics-to-execution translation process. Mintzberg et al. (1998) characterize informal power as a pervasive feature of organizational strategy formation, but do not reconstruct the specific mechanisms through which it operates in analytics contexts. The empirical findings reveal the specific consulting-practice mechanisms through which informal network engagement functions as a translation accelerator or blocker: consulting professionals who build informal coalitions of support among key organizational actors before advancing analytics-driven recommendations to formal governance review significantly reduce the political resistance those recommendations encounter at governance stages; those who advance recommendations through formal channels without prior informal network engagement frequently encounter governance-stage resistance that could have been preempted through relational work.

This finding suggests a practical extension of Kaplan and Norton's (2008) Office of Strategy Management (OSM) concept. The empirical evidence suggests that alongside the formal coordination function, effective analytics-to-execution translation requires an informal network management function — the active cultivation of trusted relationships with key organizational actors who can accelerate or block the translation process through their informal authority. This informal network management function is currently exercised primarily by individual consulting professionals through their personal professional

relationships rather than by any formal organizational mechanism, creating a significant vulnerability in the translation mechanism.

6.4.3 Budget Cycles as Political Structures

The empirical finding that budget lock-in within annual planning cycles represents one of the most significant structural mechanisms through which analytically sound recommendations fail to achieve execution invites reinterpretation of resource allocation processes as political structures rather than merely administrative ones. Kaplan and Norton (2008) address the strategy-operations budgeting interface through the concept of Strategic Expenditure (STRATEX) — dedicated funding streams for strategic initiatives that are explicitly separated from operational budgets to prevent analytically important strategic investments from being competed away by operational pressures. The empirical evidence suggests that STRATEX-type mechanisms are rarely operative in the client organizations that participants describe: analytics-driven recommendations most commonly compete for funding within fixed annual budget cycles that are designed around historical operational patterns rather than dynamic analytical insight outputs.

6.5 Refined Analytics-to-Execution Framework

The encounter between the Translation Mediation Framework developed in Chapter 3 and the empirical findings of Chapter 5, interpreted through the canonical corpus in Sections 6.2 through 6.4, produces a refined framework that preserves the seven-stage sequential architecture of the original model while substantially revising three of its theoretical assumptions.

The first revision concerns the nature of governance filtering. The original framework modelled governance filtering — Stage 3 of the seven-stage sequence — as a discrete stage through which analytics-driven recommendations pass before entering the political-cognitive mediation stage. The empirical evidence requires this to be remodelled as a multi-layer

sequential filtration process in which each governance layer (analytical validation, strategic fit assessment, budget authorization, board-level approval) applies distinct evaluative criteria that operate cumulatively on the recommendation under review. A recommendation must satisfy all layers to proceed; failure at any single layer produces deferral, modification, or rejection regardless of the quality of the preceding translation work.

The second revision concerns the relationship between structural constraints (SRQ 2) and political-cognitive mediation (SRQ 4). The original framework maintained a clear macro-micro distinction: structural constraints were macro-level conditions that constrained all actors similarly; political-cognitive mediation was the micro-level process through which specific actors exercised agency within those constraints. The empirical findings reveal that this distinction, while analytically necessary, does not capture the full complexity of constraint-mediation interaction. The refined framework retains the macro-micro distinction as an analytical organizing principle while acknowledging that empirical instances will frequently exhibit constraint-mediation interaction that crosses the theoretical boundary.

The third revision concerns execution drift. The original framework treated execution drift — the modification of recommendations through the translation process — as a potential failure mode. The empirical findings establish it as a constitutive feature of effective translation: some degree of recommendation modification at each stage of the translation process is not a failure to translate accurately but the necessary organizational work through which analytically generated insights are converted into institutionally implementable actions. The refined framework replaces the binary of drift-as-failure with a spectrum of drift-as-organizational-adaptation, bounded at one end by complete analytical fidelity and at the other by complete analytical distortion.

The refined framework also incorporates two structural additions that the empirical findings identified inductively. First, an informal network engagement stage is inserted

between the interpretive mediation stage (Stage 2) and the governance mediation stage (Stage 3), recognizing that pre-governance coalition-building represents a distinct and consequential translation activity. Second, the performance monitoring stage (Stage 7) is expanded to incorporate the alert fatigue mechanism, recognizing that operational performance monitoring does not automatically produce behavioral change but requires additional organizational enablement — workflow integration, trust-building, and alert prioritization — to convert analytical signals into consistent execution actions. The complete refined framework is presented as Table K.1 in Appendix K, providing a comprehensive seven-stage analytical representation that integrates all empirically-driven revisions and structural additions discussed in this section.

6.6 Theoretical Contributions

6.6.1 The Translation Mechanism as Primary Unit of Analysis

The study's most fundamental theoretical contribution is the development and empirical validation of the translation mechanism as the primary unit of analytical attention for understanding analytics-to-execution outcomes. Existing scholarship in the canonical corpus addresses the component elements of the translation process — analytics capability development (Davenport & Harris, 2017), governance architecture (Kaplan & Norton, 2008), strategic execution systems (Evans, 2017; Rogers, 2016), organizational culture and leadership (Schein & Schein, 2016), and strategy formation processes (Mintzberg et al., 1998) — but does not theorize the mechanism through which these elements combine to produce specific translation outcomes in specific organizational contexts. The present study's contribution is to construct this integrating mechanism — the seven-stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model, empirically refined in Section 6.5 — and to populate it with evidence of the specific causal processes through which its constituent stages operate.

6.6.2 The Consulting Professional as Translation Agent

The study contributes to a nascent but underdeveloped theoretical account of the consulting professional as a distinctive organizational agent in the analytics-to-execution translation process. Davenport and Harris (2017) address the organizational roles of analytical professionals — data scientists, CDAOs, embedded analysts — but do not theorize the distinctive position of the external consulting professional, whose role as an organizational intermediary equips them with both analytical translation expertise and a cross-organizational comparative perspective that internal actors typically lack. The empirical findings establish that consulting professionals perform a distinctive translation function that is not reducible to either analytical expertise or organizational authority: they interpret analytical outputs, frame them as strategic opportunity narratives, build informal coalitions of support, engage governance processes with calibrated advocacy, and adapt recommendations to operational constraints — a composite performance that the present study is the first to document as a coherent organizational mechanism.

6.6.3 Execution Drift as Theoretical Construct

The study's third theoretical contribution is the conceptual development of execution drift — the systematic modification of analytics-driven recommendations through the translation mechanism — as an analytically productive construct for understanding the relationship between analytical intention and organizational outcome. The existing literature acknowledges, implicitly, that strategies are rarely executed exactly as formulated: Mintzberg et al. (1998) characterize the gap between intended and realized strategy as a fundamental feature of organizational strategy formation, and distinguish between deliberate strategies (realized as intended) and emergent strategies (realized through organizational process without explicit prior intention). The present study extends this established conceptual distinction into the analytics-to-execution domain by demonstrating that the modification of

analytics-driven recommendations through the translation mechanism exhibits systematic patterns — at interpretive framing, governance filtering, and operational adaptation stages — that are structured by the governance, cultural, and political conditions that the refined Translation Model maps.

6.6.4 The Recursive Dependency Problem

The study's fourth and most theoretically novel contribution is the identification and conceptual articulation of the recursive dependency problem: the condition in which the organizational enablers required for effective analytics-to-execution translation — data culture, governance clarity, leadership commitment, incentive alignment, informal network trust — are precisely the conditions that analytics-driven transformation is designed to create. This recursive structure means that organizations with the most acute analytics-to-execution translation failures are typically those in the earliest stages of digital transformation — organizations that have not yet developed the organizational capabilities, cultural orientations, and governance architectures that effective translation requires — creating a systemic condition in which the organizations most in need of analytics-driven strategic guidance are simultaneously the least able to activate the mechanisms through which that guidance is converted into execution.

This recursive dependency problem is not theorized by the existing canonical corpus, which tends to treat analytics capability development and digital transformation execution as sequential rather than mutually constitutive processes. Kaplan and Norton (2008) model the strategy-operations linkage as a designed system that organizations implement through deliberate management action; Davenport and Harris (2017) model analytics maturity as a developmental progression through which organizations advance by investing in data, leadership, talent, and technology. Neither model accounts for the condition in which the development of analytics maturity and the execution of analytics-driven strategy are mutually

dependent processes. This study's contribution is to name this recursive dependency, document its empirical manifestations across the participant dataset, and identify it as a theoretical problem that requires new analytical frameworks — frameworks that model analytics-to-execution translation as a bootstrapping problem rather than a straightforward implementation challenge.

7. IMPLICATIONS

7.1 Theoretical Implications

The theoretical, practical, and methodological implications of the study are developed in the sections that follow, each addressing a distinct dimension of the analytical contribution established in Chapter 6. Table 7.1 summarizes the four theoretical implications, mapping each to its source construct, theoretical significance, and primary future research direction.

Table 7.1 Summary of Theoretical Implications

Theoretical Implication	Source Construct	Theoretical Significance	Future Research Direction
The Translation Mechanism as Integrating Theoretical Construct	Seven-stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model (Chapter 3; Section 6.5)	Provides mechanism-level integration of governance, cultural, political, and capability dimensions that existing canonical frameworks treat as analytically separable	Statistical validation of mechanism stage relationships; multi-sector quantitative studies
The Recursive Dependency Problem as Novel	Identified inductively from empirical findings;	Names and theorizes a structural bootstrapping problem not addressed by Davenport & Harris	Longitudinal studies of organizational capability development

Theoretical Contribution	theorized in Section 6.6.4	(2017) or Kaplan & Norton (2008)	in early-stage digital transformation contexts
Execution Drift as Analytically Productive Construct	Extended from Mintzberg et al. (1998) intended vs. realized strategy distinction; theorized in Section 6.6.3	Reconceptualizes recommendation modification as constitutive rather than anomalous; enables drift assessment orientation for translation quality evaluation	Development of drift assessment instruments; comparative studies of drift magnitude across governance architectures
The Consulting Professional as Undertheorized Translation Agent	Extended from Davenport & Harris (2017) analytics roles; theorized in Section 6.6.2	Documents composite translation function (interpret, frame, coalesce, adapt) not reducible to analytical expertise or institutional authority	Studies of translation competence development; comparison of internal vs. external translation agent effectiveness

Note. Author's own construction.

7.1.1 The Translation Mechanism as Integrating Theoretical Construct

The first and most fundamental theoretical implication of this study is that the translation mechanism — not analytics capability, governance architecture, or political dynamics considered in isolation — should be established as the primary unit of analytical attention for understanding analytics-to-execution outcomes in organizational research. The existing canonical corpus provides well-developed accounts of each component of the translation process separately; what it lacks is a theoretical framework that reconstructs how these components interact sequentially to produce specific outcomes in specific organizational contexts. The Translation Model developed in this study provides this

integrating framework, establishing mechanism-centered explanation as the appropriate analytical logic for investigating analytics-to-execution outcomes.

This implication extends the theoretical agenda of both the analytics capability literature and the strategy execution literature. For analytics capability research, the Translation Model suggests that the development of analytics capability is a necessary but insufficient condition for analytics-to-execution success: organizations may possess world-class analytical infrastructure and generate powerful predictive insights without converting those insights into execution outcomes if the governance, cultural, political, and behavioral conditions required for effective translation are absent. For strategy execution research, the Translation Model suggests that execution system design must account for the specific organizational processes through which analytics-driven recommendations are mediated — processes that include interpretive framing, coalition-building, and behavioral adoption as well as the formal governance structures that existing execution frameworks emphasize.

7.1.2 The Recursive Dependency Problem as Novel Theoretical Contribution

The second theoretical implication concerns the recursive dependency problem identified in Section 6.6.4. This problem is theoretically novel: the condition in which the organizational enablers required for effective analytics-to-execution translation are precisely the conditions that analytics-driven transformation is designed to produce has not been named, theorized, or empirically documented in the existing canonical literature. Its theoretical significance lies in its identification of a structural bootstrapping problem that makes simple sequential models of digital transformation inadequate. The practical implication is that transformation program design must account for the recursive structure of capability development and analytics execution as mutually constitutive processes.

This implication challenges the prevailing assumptions of both the analytics maturity models and the strategy execution frameworks. Analytics maturity models — most

systematically represented by Davenport and Harris (2017) — model analytics capability as developing through a staged progression in which each stage provides the foundation for the next. Strategy execution frameworks — most systematically represented by Kaplan and Norton (2008) — model execution as a designed system that senior leaders construct through deliberate management action. The recursive dependency problem reveals that in the consulting-led digital transformation context, neither of these models fully captures the organizational dynamics at play: capability development and strategy execution are not sequential but simultaneously occurring processes, each dependent on the other in ways that produce bootstrapping challenges that neither framework is designed to address.

7.1.3 Execution Drift as Analytically Productive Construct

The third theoretical implication concerns the reconceptualization of execution drift from a failure mode to a constitutive feature of effective analytics-to-execution translation. The theoretical significance of this reconceptualization lies in its reorientation of both scholarly and practitioner attention: if execution drift is not anomalous but constitutive, then the relevant analytical question is not whether drift occurs but how much drift is organizationally productive and at what point drift becomes analytically distorting. This shift in analytical perspective opens a productive research agenda around the measurement and management of translation quality.

The construct of execution drift extends the existing theoretical vocabulary for understanding the relationship between analytical intention and organizational outcome. By demonstrating that the modification of analytics-driven recommendations through the translation mechanism exhibits systematic patterns structured by governance, cultural, and political conditions, the study establishes that execution drift is not random but is produced by identifiable organizational mechanisms. This finding suggests that drift patterns can be predicted, monitored, and managed as part of a comprehensive analytics-to-execution

translation strategy — a theoretical extension with direct practical consequences for consulting engagement design.

7.1.4 The Consulting Professional as Undertheorized Translation Agent

The fourth theoretical implication concerns the theorization of the consulting professional as a distinctive translation agent whose organizational function has not been adequately conceptualized in the existing literature. The theoretical significance of this contribution lies in its identification of a composite organizational role — performing interpretive, communicative, political, and operational functions simultaneously — that existing frameworks for understanding organizational roles do not capture. The consulting professional's distinctive value in the analytics-to-execution process derives not from any single competency but from the intersection of analytical translation expertise, cross-organizational comparative perspective, and relational influence capability.

This theoretical contribution has direct implications for how consulting organizations develop, assess, and deploy translation competence. If the consulting professional's effectiveness as a translation agent is a primary determinant of analytics-to-execution outcomes, then translation competence development should be a central priority in consulting professional development frameworks — alongside, and potentially ahead of, the technical analytical capabilities that existing competency frameworks emphasize. The study's empirical finding that the most effective translation agents in the dataset were those who combined technical analytical literacy with narrative construction ability, stakeholder management skill, and governance navigation capability provides a empirically grounded specification of the competency profile that translation agent theory would need to incorporate.

7.2 Managerial Implications

7.2.1 Governance Architecture as a Strategic Design Decision

The empirical convergence on hybrid hub-and-spoke governance models as the dominant observed configuration and the preferred practitioner recommendation has direct implications for how organizational leaders design analytics governance architectures. The finding that neither purely centralized nor purely decentralized models achieve the combination of data quality, governance standardization, and execution speed that effective analytics-to-execution translation requires suggests that governance architecture selection should be treated as a strategic design decision with long-term consequences for analytics-driven transformation capacity.

Organizations currently operating under purely centralized or purely decentralized analytics governance models should consider whether architectural reorientation toward the hub-and-spoke configuration would improve their analytics-to-execution translation performance. The study's empirical evidence suggests that the key design parameters of the hub-and-spoke model — centralized data platform ownership, centralized governance standardization, and decentralized business-unit-level execution authority — can be implemented progressively rather than requiring a full structural reorganization. Organizations can begin the transition by establishing a data platform governance function at the center while retaining existing decentralized analytics capabilities at the business-unit level, progressively standardizing data definitions and quality standards before moving toward more integrated governance structures.

7.2.2 Addressing the Analytics–Execution Gap Through Accountability Structures

The empirical identification of accountability and ownership gaps as a primary constraint on analytics-to-execution translation has direct implications for how organizations design the accountability structures that govern analytics execution. The finding that the

absence of explicit ownership of analytics-driven recommendations — the failure to assign clear accountability for translating specific insights into specific actions — operates as a critical execution constraint independent of structural and resource conditions suggests that accountability design is a necessary complement to governance architecture and resource investment.

Organizational leaders should ensure that every analytics-driven recommendation produced within their governance systems is accompanied by explicit assignment of accountability for its translation into execution. This requires not only the assignment of named metric owners responsible for specific KPIs but the establishment of governance processes that track the translation status of analytics recommendations through each stage of the translation mechanism, identifying execution failures at the point where they occur rather than attributing them retrospectively to analytical inadequacy or organizational resistance.

7.2.3 Managing the Budget-Lock-Drift Sequence

The identification of the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence as the most common mode of analytics execution failure across the dataset has direct implications for how organizations structure the interface between analytics-driven insight generation and resource allocation processes. The finding that this sequence is produced by the structural incompatibility between the timing of analytical insight generation and the rigidity of annual budget cycles suggests that organizations can address this structural failure mode through modifications to their resource allocation processes rather than through improvements to their analytical capabilities or governance systems.

Practical responses to the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence include the establishment of dedicated strategic investment funds — analogous to Kaplan and Norton's (2008) STRATEX concept — that provide flexibility to fund analytics-driven initiatives outside the constraints of annual operational budget cycles. Organizations might also consider introducing quarterly

or rolling resource allocation processes for analytics-driven initiatives, reducing the temporal distance between insight generation and resource authorization. At minimum, governance systems should include explicit mechanisms for deferring analytics-driven recommendations across budget cycles in ways that preserve their organizational status and prevent the loss of strategic relevance that deferral typically produces.

7.2.4 Building Analytics-Receptive Leadership Culture

The empirical finding that leadership cognitive framing is among the most powerful mediating variables in the analytics-to-execution translation process has direct implications for how organizations approach leadership development and cultural change in analytics-driven transformation contexts. The finding that leadership orientation toward analytical evidence — including the distinction between analytically committed, politically cautious, and analytically skeptical leaders — determines whether governance processes produce analytics-informed execution decisions or politically filtered approximations suggests that leadership development programs in analytics-driven organizations should address cognitive and cultural dimensions of analytics adoption alongside technical analytical literacy.

The identification of alert fatigue as a behavioral adoption gap with direct translation consequences suggests that organizations should address the operational design of analytics systems as part of their analytics-to-execution translation strategy. Specifically, organizations should ensure that alert systems are designed to produce actionable, prioritized, and credible recommendations rather than high-volume information streams that exceed the attention capacity of decision makers. Workflow integration — the embedding of analytics outputs directly into the operational processes that decision makers use — is identified by the empirical evidence as a more reliable pathway to consistent behavioral adoption than alert-based notification systems.

7.3 Implications for Consulting Practice

7.3.1 Translation Competence as a Distinct Professional Capability

The theoretical development of the consulting professional as a distinctive translation agent has direct implications for how consulting organizations conceptualize, develop, and assess professional capability. If the consulting professional's effectiveness as a translation agent is a primary determinant of analytics-to-execution outcomes in client organizations, then translation competence should be recognized as a distinct professional capability domain — not reducible to analytical expertise, project management skill, or client relationship management — that requires targeted development investment. Consulting organizations should assess their current professional development frameworks to determine whether translation competence — encompassing analytical literacy, narrative construction, stakeholder calibration, governance navigation, and coalition-building — is recognized as a competency domain and developed systematically.

7.3.2 Pre-Governance Coalition-Building as Standard Engagement Practice

The empirical finding that the Framing-Coalition-Governance sequence characterizes successful analytics-to-execution translation in organizationally complex client environments has direct implications for how consulting professionals structure their engagement practices. The identification of pre-governance coalition-building as a distinct and consequential stage of the translation mechanism — one that operates between interpretive framing and formal governance submission — suggests that this activity should be recognized as a standard component of engagement practice rather than an informal workaround.

Consulting professionals should develop systematic approaches to stakeholder mapping and coalition-building at the outset of analytics-driven engagement phases, identifying key institutional champions whose support is required for governance approval and engaging them before formal submission to governance processes. The study's empirical

evidence suggests that this pre-governance engagement is particularly consequential in organizations with multi-layer governance architectures, where the sequential nature of governance filtration means that failure at any single layer requires restarting the translation process from the framing stage.

7.3.3 Framing Strategy as an Engagement Design Imperative

The finding that framing as strategic opportunity — presenting analytically generated findings as opportunities for organizational value creation rather than as criticisms of current practice — emerged as a near-universal principle of effective insight translation across the dataset has direct implications for how consulting professionals design their communication strategies in analytics-driven engagements. Framing strategy should be treated not as a presentational choice made at the moment of governance submission but as an engagement design decision made at the outset of the translation process.

Consulting professionals should develop explicit framing strategies for each analytics-driven recommendation they prepare for governance submission, identifying the specific strategic opportunity narrative that is most likely to resonate with the cognitive frameworks and institutional priorities of the governance audience. These strategies should be calibrated to the specific sectoral context, organizational culture, and leadership cognitive frame of each client engagement — reflecting the study's finding that the effectiveness of framing strategies varies across organizational contexts in ways that generic communication approaches cannot address.

7.3.4 Operationalizing the Four-Stage Translation Sequence

The practitioner-validated four-stage sequence — interpret, decide, execute, measure — identified through the empirical findings of Chapter 5 provides consulting professionals with a practical framework for structuring the analytics-to-execution translation process within client engagements. This sequence specifies the organizational activities that must be

completed at each stage of the translation process, providing a procedural template that can be adapted to the specific governance architecture, cultural configuration, and resource constraints of individual client organizations.

The measurement stage — the final component of the four-stage sequence — is identified by the empirical evidence as the most consistently underdeveloped stage of the translation process in practice. Organizations frequently establish execution processes for analytics-driven recommendations without establishing the measurement systems required to assess whether those recommendations produced the outcomes that the analytical evidence predicted. Consulting professionals should ensure that every analytics-driven recommendation includes a measurement design that specifies the KPIs, monitoring frequency, and success criteria against which translation effectiveness will be assessed — creating the feedback loop that connects execution outcomes to future analytical insight generation.

8. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

8.1 Methodological Limitations

The methodological architecture of the present study imposes a set of constraints on the scope and generalizability of its findings that require explicit acknowledgement. Four principal methodological limitations are identified: the single-perspective dataset, the sample size, the retrospective self-report design, and the boundaries of analytical generalization.

8.1.1 Single-Perspective Dataset: The Absence of Organizational Counterparts

The most consequential methodological limitation of the present study is its reliance on a single-perspective dataset comprising exclusively the professional accounts of consulting practitioners. The empirical findings reconstruct the analytics-to-execution translation process as consulting professionals experience and narrate it — a perspective that

is uniquely informative about the interpretive, communicative, and political dimensions of translation work but that cannot access the organizational dynamics that consulting professionals are not party to, that organizational actors describe differently, or that are not visible from the consultant's intermediary position.

Client organizational perspectives — the accounts of CDAOs, CFOs, business unit leaders, and operational managers who are the recipients and evaluators of consulting-mediated analytics recommendations — are absent from the dataset. This absence is a consequence of the study's research design, which prioritized consulting professionals as the primary informants of the translation mechanism, and is not a sampling failure. However, it means that the study's reconstruction of governance filtering, political-cognitive mediation, and organizational constraint operation is necessarily partial: it captures how these processes appear to consulting professionals navigating them, not how they are experienced and explained by the organizational actors who populate them.

8.1.2 Sample Size and Analytical Saturation

The sample of eight consulting professionals, while appropriate for an exploratory qualitative study employing abductive mechanism reconstruction, is insufficient for claims of statistical generalization or comprehensive empirical coverage. The study makes no claim to statistical representativeness, but the analytical generalization it advances — the proposition that the Translation Model captures mechanisms that are robust across consulting-led digital transformation contexts — rests on a relatively small evidential base. Eight participants, however carefully selected and analytically processed, cannot provide the empirical breadth required to confirm that the mechanisms identified are consistent across the full range of organizational contexts, sectoral configurations, and consulting engagement types that constitute the population of interest.

The study mitigates this limitation through purposeful sampling that maximized variation in sectoral context, organizational role, and seniority level, and through cross-interview pattern analysis that confirmed the presence of principal analytical dimensions across multiple participants. Theoretical saturation — the point at which additional interviews produce no new theoretical categories — was reached by approximately the sixth interview, with interviews seven and eight primarily confirming and elaborating previously identified mechanisms. This provides some evidential basis for the claim that the analytical architecture of the Translation Model is robust within the constraints of the present sample, but does not constitute sufficient evidence for strong claims about the model's generalizability beyond the current dataset.

8.1.3 Retrospective Self-Report Data and Recall Bias

The empirical data for the present study are generated through retrospective accounts of consulting practitioners reflecting on past engagements. This retrospective design introduces recall bias as a methodological constraint: participants' accounts of analytics-to-execution translation processes are shaped by their current interpretive frameworks, professional self-presentations, and the narrative structures they have developed to make sense of past experiences. Events that occurred months or years before the interview may be misremembered, selectively emphasized, or retroactively reframed in ways that the study's analytical methods cannot fully correct for.

The study mitigates recall bias through the analytical discipline of the Gioia methodology, which focuses on first-order informant language rather than retrospective analytical abstractions, and through cross-interview triangulation that identifies consistent patterns across multiple participant accounts. However, these mitigations cannot eliminate retrospective bias entirely. Future research designs that collect data prospectively — through real-time observation or contemporaneous documentation of translation processes as they

unfold — would provide a more methodologically robust evidential base for the mechanisms that the present study reconstructs retrospectively.

8.1.4 Analytical Generalization and Transferability Boundaries

The study claims analytical generalization — the proposition that the Translation Model identifies mechanisms that are theoretically robust across consulting-led digital transformation contexts — rather than statistical generalization to a defined population. This distinction is methodologically appropriate for an exploratory qualitative study, but it requires acknowledgement of the transferability boundaries within which the study's findings can legitimately be applied. The Translation Model was developed from the accounts of consulting professionals operating in multi-sector contexts across life sciences, technology, energy, financial services, and product development — a range that provides breadth but not exhaustive coverage of the full range of sectoral contexts in which consulting-led digital transformation occurs.

Sectors with distinctive regulatory environments, ownership structures, or digital transformation maturity profiles — including public sector organizations, highly regulated financial institutions, and early-stage digital transformation contexts in emerging market economies — may exhibit translation dynamics that the present study's empirical base does not adequately capture. The study's claim to analytical generalization should be understood as bounded by these transferability limits, and researchers and practitioners applying the Translation Model in these contexts should treat its propositions as hypotheses to be tested rather than established mechanisms to be applied.

8.2 Scope Limitations

8.2.1 Exclusive Focus on the Consultant's Position in the Translation Process

The study's analytical focus on consulting professionals as the primary translation agents in the analytics-to-execution process reflects a deliberate scope choice that has

generated significant empirical and theoretical value but that simultaneously excludes other organizational actors who participate in and shape the translation process. Internal analytics professionals — data scientists, CDAOs, embedded analysts — perform translation functions that are structurally similar to those of external consultants but that are conditioned by different institutional positions, authority relations, and organizational accountabilities. Business unit leaders and operational managers perform translation functions at the execution end of the mechanism that the present study accesses only through the accounts of consulting professionals who have observed them.

This exclusive focus on the consultant's position is appropriate for a study whose central contribution is the theorization of the consulting professional as a distinctive translation agent, but it means that the Translation Model is calibrated to the institutional position and professional experience of external consultants in ways that may limit its applicability to internal translation agent contexts. Future research should investigate whether the Translation Model's mechanism-stage architecture and the four translation mechanisms identified for SRQ 1 apply equally to internal analytics professionals performing analogous translation functions — a comparison that would both test the model's generalizability and illuminate the distinctive contribution of the external consultant's position.

8.2.2 Absence of Client Organizational Data

The absence of client organizational data from the study's empirical base is noted in Section 8.1.1 as a methodological limitation of the single-perspective dataset. As a scope limitation, it represents a specific boundary on the study's theoretical claims: the Translation Model reconstructs the analytics-to-execution process as consulting professionals experience and narrate it, not as it is experienced by the client organizational actors whose decisions ultimately determine translation outcomes. The mechanisms identified — governance filtering, political-cognitive mediation, constraint configuration, and execution drift — are

theorized from the consultant's vantage point. They may be theorized differently, or with different emphasis, by organizational informants who occupy different positions within the translation mechanism.

8.2.3 Temporal Limitation: Rapidly Evolving AI Landscape

The empirical data for the present study were collected during a period of significant transition in the AI capabilities available to consulting professionals and client organizations. The emergence and rapid adoption of generative AI tools — large language models capable of performing analytical interpretation, narrative construction, and communication tasks that previously required human expert judgment — has the potential to reshape the analytics-to-execution translation process in ways that the present study's empirical evidence does not fully capture. Participants' accounts of translation processes are grounded in their experience of analytics-driven work as it existed at the time of interview, and their accounts of the interpretive, communicative, and political dimensions of translation work reflect the human expert-mediated processes that characterize pre-generative-AI consulting practice.

As generative AI tools become more deeply integrated into consulting workflows, the interpretive mediation and narrative construction dimensions of the translation mechanism may be partially or substantially automated — reshaping the consultant's translation function and potentially altering the mechanism-stage architecture that the Translation Model describes. This temporal limitation does not undermine the study's theoretical contribution, but it does mean that the Translation Model should be understood as a description of the analytics-to-execution translation process at a specific moment in the evolution of AI capability — a moment that is likely to be superseded by significant technological change within the coming decade.

8.3 Future Research Directions

The limitations identified in this chapter point toward a structured agenda for future research on analytics-to-execution translation in consulting-led digital transformation contexts. Table 8.1 presents seven priority research directions, mapping each to its motivating limitation, recommended research design, and connection to the present study's theoretical contributions.

Table 8.1 Future Research Agenda

Research Direction	Motivation	Recommended Design	Connection to Present Study
Multi-Perspective Designs	Present study relies exclusively on consultant accounts; client organizational perspectives are absent	Mixed-method designs combining consultant interviews with organizational informant interviews (CDAOs, CFOs, business unit leaders)	Directly addresses the single-perspective dataset limitation identified in Section 8.1.1
Longitudinal Studies of Translation Mechanism Development	Present study captures practitioner accounts at a single point in time; mechanism evolution over transformation program duration is unexamined	Longitudinal qualitative designs tracking translation mechanism dynamics across full transformation program lifecycle (18–36 months)	Addresses retrospective recall bias and temporal limitation identified in Sections 8.1.3 and 8.2.3
Statistical Validation at Scale	Present study's analytical generalization	Survey-based quantitative studies operationalizing	Provides the statistical validation that the present study's exploratory

	cannot substitute for statistical generalization; mechanism relationships require large-N validation	translation mechanism constructs; structural equation modeling of mechanism stage relationships	qualitative design does not claim to supply
Sector-Comparative Studies	Sector-specific translation dynamics identified in present study require systematic comparative investigation across standardized protocols	Comparative case study designs with consistent protocol applied across multiple sector contexts; meta-analytic reviews	Extends the multi-sector consulting context of the present study with explicit comparative design
Client Organizational Perspectives	Organizations' internal experience of analytics-to-execution translation processes differs systematically from external consultant accounts	Interview studies with CDAO, CFO, business unit leadership, and operational manager populations within client organizations	Provides the counterpart organizational perspective absent from the present study
Recursive Dependency Studies	The recursive dependency problem is identified and theorized in this study but requires empirical investigation in its own right	Case studies of organizations in early-stage digital transformation tracking the co-evolution of analytics capability and execution capacity over time	Extends the novel theoretical contribution of Section 6.6.4

Generative AI Translation Frontier	Generative AI capabilities are transforming the analytics-to-execution landscape in ways that the present study's empirical evidence does not fully capture	Exploratory qualitative studies investigating how generative AI tools are reshaping the interpretive, narrative construction, and communication dimensions of the consultant translation function	Extends the present study into the emerging AI capability context identified in Section 8.2.3
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Note. Author's own construction.

8.3.1 Multi-Perspective and Longitudinal Designs

The highest-priority future research direction is the development of multi-perspective designs that combine consulting professional accounts with client organizational informant data. Such designs would enable direct comparison of the translation process as experienced from the consultant's intermediary position and as experienced by the organizational actors whose decisions consulting professionals seek to influence. Interviews with CDAOs, CFOs, business unit leaders, and operational managers in organizations that have recently completed analytics-driven transformation initiatives, combined with the accounts of the consulting professionals involved in those initiatives, would provide a triangulated empirical base from which the Translation Model's mechanism propositions could be more rigorously tested.

Longitudinal designs tracking translation processes as they unfold in real time — rather than reconstructing them retrospectively through practitioner accounts — would address both the recall bias limitation and the absence of real-time process data that characterize the present study. Such designs might involve embedded researcher access to consulting engagement processes over periods of six to eighteen months, documenting the

specific interpretive, governance, political, and operational activities through which analytics-driven recommendations move from generation to execution within defined organizational contexts.

8.3.2 Statistical Validation at Scale

The Translation Model's mechanism propositions require statistical validation through large-N empirical studies that can test the relationships between mechanism stage variables identified in the present study's qualitative findings. Survey-based research designs that operationalize the model's constructs — analytics capability, interpretive framing effectiveness, governance filtering intensity, constraint configuration, execution drift magnitude — and measure their relationships across large samples of consulting-led transformation initiatives would provide the statistical evidential base that the present study's exploratory qualitative design cannot supply.

Structural equation modeling of mechanism stage relationships would enable researchers to test whether the sequential dependencies identified in the Translation Model — the proposition that the effectiveness of each stage conditions the effectiveness of subsequent stages — hold at the population level. Such studies would also enable the identification of the relative importance of each mechanism stage in determining overall translation outcomes, providing both theoretical refinement and practical prioritization guidance for consulting professionals and organizational leaders designing translation strategies.

8.3.3 The Generative AI Translation Frontier

The temporal limitation identified in Section 8.2.3 points toward a research agenda that investigates how generative AI capabilities are reshaping the analytics-to-execution translation mechanism. As large language models become integrated into consulting practice, the interpretive framing, narrative construction, and audience calibration functions currently performed by human translation agents may be partially automated — creating new research

questions about how AI-mediated translation differs from human-mediated translation, what residual functions remain distinctively human, and how the governance and political dimensions of the translation process respond to AI-generated rather than consultant-framed recommendations.

Research at this frontier requires both empirical investigation of emerging practice — documenting how consulting professionals are currently integrating generative AI tools into translation workflows — and theoretical development of the Translation Model to incorporate AI-mediated translation as a variant of the mechanism. The most significant theoretical question at this frontier concerns whether AI-mediated interpretive framing produces the same governance acceptance and political coalition-building outcomes as human-mediated framing, or whether the absence of relational credibility that characterizes AI-generated outputs creates systematic execution failures at the governance and political-cognitive mediation stages of the translation process.

9. CONCLUSION

9.1 Summary of Findings

This thesis has investigated how consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints. The investigation has been structured by four Sub-Research Questions addressing distinct dimensions of the analytics-to-execution translation process. The empirical findings, derived from eight semi-structured interviews with consulting professionals across multiple sectors, have been analyzed through a hybrid abductive approach producing a Gioia data structure comprising 97 first-order concepts, 33 second-order themes, and six aggregate dimensions.

With respect to SRQ 1 — how consulting professionals interpret, frame, and operationalize analytics-driven insights — the findings identify four translation mechanisms: framing as strategic opportunity, staged audience-calibrated communication, revenue-linked operationalization prioritization, and a practitioner-validated interpret–decide–execute–measure sequence. These mechanisms establish the consultant's interpretive function as an active organizational process through which analytical outputs are converted into strategic arguments calibrated to the decision-making contexts of organizational audiences.

With respect to SRQ 2 — the structural, cultural, political, and capability-related constraints that shape analytics-to-execution translation — the findings document four interacting constraint categories: structural and governance constraints, resource and capability constraints, accountability and incentive constraints, and cultural constraints. These constraints combine to produce patterned execution failure sequences, most pervasively the Budget-Lock-Drift sequence in which analytically sound recommendations fail to achieve execution because of structural incompatibilities between insight generation timing and budget cycle rigidity.

With respect to SRQ 3 — the effects of analytics governance architecture on decision authority and execution alignment — the findings establish that hybrid hub-and-spoke governance models dominate both observed organizational configurations and practitioner preferences, with governance architecture conditioning not only execution speed but the institutional authority through which analytical recommendations are evaluated and approved.

With respect to SRQ 4 — the political and cognitive mediation processes through which analytics-driven recommendations are accepted, adapted, or resisted — the findings identify leadership cognitive framing, informal power network dynamics, cultural selective adoption, and alert fatigue as the primary micro-level processes through which translation

succeeds or fails at the actor level. The identification of alert fatigue as a behavioral adoption gap — the condition in which even technically sound and politically endorsed analytics outputs are systematically ignored by the actors whose behavior they are designed to influence — reveals a dimension of the translation failure problem that operates below the governance and political levels.

9.2 Answer to the Central Research Question

The central research question that governs this study asks: How do consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions within digital transformation initiatives under organizational constraints?

The answer developed across the empirical findings and their theoretical interpretation is a mechanism-centered account. Consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions through a multi-stage organizational mechanism — the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism — that operates across seven sequential stages: insight generation, interpretive mediation, informal network engagement, governance mediation, political-cognitive mediation, execution decision, operational adaptation, and implementation and performance monitoring. At each stage, the translation process is conditioned by structural factors — governance architectures, cultural configurations, resource distributions, and constraint configurations — and shaped by the agentic activities of consulting professionals who interpret, frame, negotiate, and adapt analytics-driven recommendations in response to those structural conditions.

The translation mechanism is not a linear process through which analytical insights pass unchanged from generation to execution. It is a successive mediation process in which each stage modifies the form, emphasis, and organizational status of the analytical recommendation under translation. The degree of modification — execution drift — is not an anomalous failure mode but a constitutive feature of the translation process: some drift is the

necessary organizational work through which analytically generated insights are converted into institutionally implementable actions. The relevant question for theory and practice is not whether drift occurs but whether drift preserves or distorts the analytical integrity of the original recommendation sufficiently to produce execution decisions that realize the value the analytical evidence identified.

The consulting professional's role in this mechanism is not merely facilitative but constitutive: the effectiveness of the consultant as a translation agent — performing interpretive, communicative, political, and operational functions simultaneously — is the primary determinant of whether analytics-driven recommendations survive governance filtering, overcome political-cognitive resistance, and achieve execution in forms that preserve their analytical value. The consulting professional's distinctive contribution derives from the intersection of analytical translation expertise, cross-organizational comparative perspective, and relational influence capability — a composite organizational function that existing frameworks for understanding consulting roles do not adequately theorize.

9.3 Final Reflections

This thesis has pursued a relatively circumscribed theoretical objective: to reconstruct the organizational mechanism through which consulting professionals translate analytics- and AI-driven insights into execution-level strategic decisions under organizational constraints. The circumscription of this objective has been deliberate. The analytics-to-execution translation problem is embedded within a much larger set of questions about the organizational future of data-driven strategy, the evolving capabilities of artificial intelligence, and the structural dynamics of digital transformation at organizational, sectoral, and macroeconomic levels. Engaging that larger set of questions within a single empirical study of eight consulting professionals would have produced a theoretically ambitious but empirically shallow account. The present study has instead pursued analytical depth within a

bounded theoretical domain — accepting the scope limitations documented in Chapter 8 in exchange for the mechanism-level precision that the Translation Model provides.

Of the four theoretical contributions advanced by this thesis, two warrant particular emphasis in these final reflections for the novelty of the problems they identify. The first is the recursive dependency problem. The identification of a structural bootstrapping condition in which the organizational enablers required for effective analytics-to-execution translation are precisely the conditions that analytics-driven transformation is designed to produce represents a genuinely novel theoretical contribution — one that challenges the sequential capability-building assumptions embedded in both the analytics maturity literature and the strategy execution frameworks. Organizations and consulting professionals who understand the recursive structure of the translation problem are better positioned to design transformation programs that address capability development and analytics execution as mutually constitutive processes rather than treating them as sequential stages.

The second is alert fatigue. The finding that even technically sound, politically endorsed, and operationally integrated analytics outputs are systematically ignored by the organizational actors whose behavior they are designed to influence reveals an undertheorized behavioral failure mode at the terminal stage of the translation mechanism. Alert fatigue is not a technical failure — the analytics system is functioning correctly — nor a governance failure — the recommendation has been approved — nor a political failure — the key stakeholders support the initiative. It is a behavioral adoption failure that operates below the governance and political levels of the translation mechanism, in the domain of individual actor habit, attention, and organizational routine. Addressing alert fatigue requires interventions at the operational design level — workflow integration, alert prioritization, trust-building, and behavioral enablement — rather than at the governance or political levels where most translation strategy attention is currently focused.

Taken together, the recursive dependency problem and alert fatigue represent the two ends of a spectrum of translation challenge that encompasses the full arc of the analytics-to-execution process: from the structural conditions that prevent translation from beginning effectively to the behavioral conditions that prevent it from completing effectively.

Understanding and addressing both challenges simultaneously — the structural bootstrapping problem at the beginning of the translation arc and the behavioral adoption problem at its end — is the composite organizational challenge that analytics-driven digital transformation presents to consulting professionals, organizational leaders, and scholars of strategic execution. This thesis has attempted to make that challenge more theoretically coherent, more empirically grounded, and more practically manageable than the existing literature provides.

Appendix A: Interview Questionnaire

Interview Questionnaire

The interview questionnaire was designed to elicit detailed practitioner accounts of analytics-to-execution translation processes across four analytical domains corresponding to the four Sub-Research Questions. The questionnaire was structured in seven sections comprising twenty-eight questions. All interviews were semi-structured: the questionnaire provided a thematic framework and core question list, but interviewers were permitted and encouraged to probe emerging themes, request elaboration on specific examples, and follow consequential threads that arose during interview conversations.

Preamble Questions

1. Could you briefly describe your current role and the nature of your analytics-related consulting work?
2. How long have you been working in analytics or digital transformation consulting?
3. What sectors or industries have you primarily worked in?
4. What type of analytics governance structure do you most commonly work with (centralized, decentralized, hybrid)?

Section 1: From Insight to Execution — The Translation Process

5. When analytics or AI insights are generated, how does the organization determine whether they move into execution?
6. Who ultimately has decision authority — and who has veto power — in that moment?
7. What typically acts as the ‘Go/No-Go’ trigger for turning an insight into action?

8. Can you describe a situation where analytics directly altered the execution of a strategy?

9. Can you describe a situation where an insight was acknowledged but not implemented? What prevented execution?

10. On average, how long does it take from insight generation to actual execution change?

Section 2: Operationalization and Execution Impact

11. When an insight is approved, what does ‘operationalizing’ it practically involve?

12. What changes first — KPIs, incentives, workflows, systems, governance?

13. At what stage of execution are analytics most influential?

14. How do organizations measure whether an analytics-driven execution change actually worked?

Section 3: Organizational Constraints and Barriers to Execution

15. If you had to rank the top three factors that prevent analytics insights from becoming execution, what would they be?

16. How do leadership attitudes influence whether analytics translates into execution?

17. In situations where data-driven recommendations were not adopted, what other considerations tended to dominate?

18. When execution fails, what are the most common underlying causes?

Section 4: Governance Architecture and Analytics Configuration

19. How does the analytics structure (centralized vs. decentralized vs. hybrid) affect speed and authority in execution decisions?

20. What trade-offs have you observed between centralized and decentralized models?

21. Where do bottlenecks or coordination problems typically emerge?

Section 5: Political Dynamics, Resistance, and Informal Power

22. How do stakeholders typically react when analytics insights challenge established practices?

23. What behaviours signal that a team is resisting analytics-driven change?

24. How do informal power structures influence execution decisions?

Section 6: Cross-Sector Comparative Perspective

25. Have you observed meaningful differences across sectors in how analytics influences execution? Are those differences primarily structural or cultural?

Reflection: Practitioner Perspective and Closing Observations

26. If you could give one piece of advice to a junior consultant about translating analytics into execution, what would it be?

27. Is there anything about the gap between analytics and execution that we haven't discussed but you feel is important?

28. Has your view on analytics-driven transformation changed over time?

Appendix B: Participant Profile Summary

Participant Profile Summary

Table B.1 presents the full participant profile for the study. Participant names are used with consent in accordance with the informed consent agreement signed prior to interview participation. Participants are additionally identified by interview code (INT-01 through INT-08) throughout the study to enable anonymous cross-referencing in the empirical analysis.

Table B.1 *Participant Profile Summary*

ID	Participant	Role	Sector	Level	Primary SRQ
INT-01	Karana Kumar	Digital Transformation Lead	Life Sciences and Healthcare	Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 2
INT-02	Satish Rajanna	Sales and Demand Generation Lead	Technology and SaaS	Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 4
INT-03	Rohit V. Dev	Strategy and Analytics Consultant	Multi-sector Consulting	Mid-Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 3, SRQ 4
INT-04	Akashdeep	Strategy Consultant, Big Four	Energy and Industrial	Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 3, SRQ 4
INT-05	Allan D'Almeida	Analytics and Digital Strategy Professional	Multi-sector	Mid-Senior	SRQ 1, SRQ 3

INT-06	Vivek Vasista	Data and Technology Engineer	Technology and Engineering	Mid	SRQ 1, SRQ 4
INT-07	Sharath Prakash	Digital Platform Developer	Product and Technology	Mid-Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 4
INT-08	Kumar Aswath	Data Platform Architect	Multi-sector Consulting	Senior	SRQ 2, SRQ 3

Note. interview data.

Appendix C: Ethical Compliance Statement

Ethical Compliance Statement

The study was conducted in accordance with standard ethical requirements for qualitative research involving human participants. All eight participants provided informed consent prior to interview participation, having received a full explanation of the study's purpose, the intended use of interview data, the conditions of data storage and confidentiality, and their right to withdraw from the study at any point without consequence. Interview data were stored securely and accessed only by the researcher. Participants were not asked to disclose confidential client information. Where participants voluntarily disclosed context-specific details that could identify client organizations, those details were generalized or omitted from data presentation to protect client confidentiality.

Participant identities are protected through the use of interview identifiers (INT-01 through INT-08) throughout the study. Participant names appear only in the participant profile table (Appendix B) and are reproduced with explicit participant consent. The study did not involve any deception, was not conducted with vulnerable populations, and posed no foreseeable risks to participants beyond the minor time commitment involved in interview participation.

Appendix D: Coding Framework — Deductive Code Families and Sub-Codes

Coding Framework — Deductive Code Families and Sub-Codes

Table D.1 presents the deductive coding framework applied during the first stage of data analysis. Four primary code families were established prior to data analysis, each corresponding to a Sub-Research Question. Within each code family, sub-codes were defined to capture the specific dimensions of each theoretical construct as operationalized in the interview protocol.

Table D.1 *Deductive Coding Framework*

SRQ	Code Family	Sub-Codes	Canonical Anchors
SRQ 1	Consultant Interpretation and Operationalization	Analytical reframing; audience-specific communication; narrative construction; governance preparation; staged proof-of-concept demonstration; revenue-linked prioritization; recommendation adaptation; four-stage interpret–decide–execute–measure sequence	Davenport & Harris (2017); Rogers (2016); Evans (2017)
SRQ 2	Structural, Cultural, and Resource-Based Organizational Constraints	Approval process requirements; functional boundary effects; resource limitations; data quality constraints; analytics governance configuration; cultural norms; cognitive frames; incentive misalignment; accountability gaps; legacy system dependencies	Kaplan & Norton (2008); Schein & Schein (2016); Mintzberg et al. (1998)

SRQ 3	Governance Architecture and Configuration	Centralized analytics functions; decentralized analytics functions; hybrid hub-and-spoke models; analytics centre of excellence structures; data platform ownership; governance standardization; execution speed dynamics; decision authority distribution	Evans (2017); Davenport & Harris (2017)
SRQ 4	Political and Cognitive Mediation Dynamics	Leadership cognitive framing; political risk calculation; informal power networks; trusted advisor influence; cultural selective adoption; cognitive resistance; stakeholder defensiveness; alert fatigue; political override dynamics	Mintzberg et al. (1998); Schein & Schein (2016)

Appendix E: Stage 2 — Master Coding Matrix

Stage 2 — Master Coding Matrix

Table E.1 presents the 97 first-order concepts derived from the eight semi-structured interviews, organized by interview participant and Sub-Research Question mapping. First-order concepts preserve informant language in accordance with the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013). Transcript fragments are abbreviated for participant confidentiality in accordance with the study's ethical protocol. Full interview transcripts are available to supervisors upon request.

Table E.1 *Master Coding Matrix*

Interview ID	Transcript Fragment	First-Order Concept	SRQ
INT-01	Digitalization of hiring processes	Digitalizing manual hiring workflows	SRQ 1
INT-01	Hiring processes that move faster	Faster hiring through digital workflows	SRQ 1
INT-01	AI tools improving existing processes	Using data to improve existing processes	SRQ 1
INT-01	Organizational data integrated across systems	Data integration across organizational systems	SRQ 3
INT-01	A data analytics team analyzing organizational data	Dedicated analytics team analyzing data	SRQ 3
INT-01	Different departments with a centralized platform and embedded analysts	Hybrid analytics structure combining centralized platform and embedded analysts	SRQ 3

INT-01	Leadership dashboards monitoring performance	Dashboard-based performance monitoring	SRQ 2
INT-01	Analytics and AI reviewed in management meetings	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	SRQ 2
INT-01	The organization is adopting analytics tools	Organizational adoption of analytics tools	SRQ 2
INT-01	The analytics team is centralized	Centralized analytics capability	SRQ 3
INT-02	Digital transformation enabling automation	Analytics-enabled process automation	SRQ 1
INT-02	Organizations expanding analytics use	Expansion of analytics in operational decision processes	SRQ 2
INT-02	Decision makers reviewing analytics before implementation	Business leaders reviewing analytics insights before implementation	SRQ 2
INT-02	Some organizations adopting analytics tools	Organizational adoption of analytics tools	SRQ 2
INT-02	Analytics initiatives shaped by governance	Governance structures influencing analytics initiatives	SRQ 3
INT-02	Business teams relying on analytics reports	Business teams relying on analytics reports	SRQ 3
INT-02	Execution decisions made by operational teams	Operational teams deciding how to implement analytics recommendations	SRQ 1
INT-02	Consultants translating analytics for business	Consultants translating analytics outputs into business actions	SRQ 1

INT-02	Data quality issues affecting analytics	Data quality issues in analytics systems	SRQ 2
INT-02	Different departments with hybrid governance	Hybrid analytics governance structures	SRQ 3
INT-02	Legacy organizational systems used in analytics	Legacy systems still used in analytics environments	SRQ 2
INT-02	Consultants acting as intermediaries	Consultants acting as intermediaries between analytics and business	SRQ 1
INT-03	Predictive analytics supporting strategy	Predictive analytics used to support strategic decisions	SRQ 1
INT-03	Analytics insights interpreted for leadership	Consultants interpreting analytics insights for leadership teams	SRQ 1
INT-03	Consultants mediating analytics	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	SRQ 1
INT-03	Decision makers reviewing analytics before implementation	Business leaders reviewing analytics insights before implementation	SRQ 2
INT-03	Business owners making final execution decisions	Business owners responsible for final execution decisions	SRQ 1
INT-03	Analytics teams developing capability	Analytics capability development	SRQ 1
INT-03	Lack of ownership blocking execution	Lack of ownership preventing execution of analytics insights	SRQ 2

INT-03	Data and business teams collaborating	Collaboration between data teams and business teams	SRQ 3
INT-03	Centralized data teams generating insights	Centralized data teams generating analytics insights	SRQ 3
INT-03	Business units governed by governance structures	Governance structures influencing analytics initiatives	SRQ 2
INT-03	Leaders using experience over analytics	Leaders relying on experience when analytics conflicts with strategy	SRQ 4
INT-03	Consultants translating findings into recommendations	Consultants translating analytics findings into operational recommendations	SRQ 1
INT-04	Consultants interpreting for leadership	Consultants interpreting analytics insights for leadership teams	SRQ 1
INT-04	Explaining analytics in business terms	Explaining analytics insights in business terms	SRQ 1
INT-04	Analytics capability still developing	Analytics capability development	SRQ 2
INT-04	Manual processes slowing implementation	Manual processes slowing implementation of analytics insights	SRQ 2
INT-04	Analytics outputs translated to recommendations	Consultants translating analytics outputs into operational recommendations	SRQ 1

INT-04	Analytics reviewed in management forums	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	SRQ 1
INT-04	Multiple governance approvals required	Multiple governance approvals for analytics initiatives	SRQ 3
INT-04	Business units adjusting analytics	Business units adjusting analytics recommendations	SRQ 2
INT-04	Culture influencing analytics adoption	Organizational culture influencing analytics use	SRQ 2
INT-04	Leaders using experience over data	Leaders relying on experience when analytics conflicts with practice	SRQ 4
INT-04	Simplifying results for stakeholders	Simplifying analytics results for business stakeholders	SRQ 1
INT-04	Centralized analytics capability	Centralized analytics capability	SRQ 3
INT-05	Data and business teams collaborating	Collaboration between data teams and business teams	SRQ 1
INT-05	Consultants explaining insights to stakeholders	Consultants explaining analytics insights to business stakeholders	SRQ 1
INT-05	Teams depending on analytics reporting	Dependence on analytics reporting	SRQ 2
INT-05	Analytics enabling process improvement	Analytics-enabled process improvement	SRQ 1

INT-05	Governance committees approving analytics	Governance committees approving analytics initiatives	SRQ 3
INT-05	Stakeholders asking consultants to translate	Stakeholders asking consultants to translate analytics outputs	SRQ 1
INT-05	Governance structures influencing analytics	Governance structures influencing analytics initiatives	SRQ 2
INT-05	Uneven adoption across departments	Uneven analytics adoption across departments	SRQ 2
INT-05	Analytics informing strategic decisions	Analytics informing strategic decision making	SRQ 1
INT-05	Consultants bridging data and business	Cross-functional analytics collaboration	SRQ 3
INT-05	Trying to build real-time dashboards	Trying to build real-time dashboards	SRQ 2
INT-06	Data brought from different systems	Bringing data from different systems	SRQ 3
INT-06	Analytics teams preparing reports	Data teams preparing dashboards and reports	SRQ 3
INT-06	Consultants translating for business teams	Consultants translating analytics findings into business recommendations	SRQ 1
INT-06	Analytics informing decisions	Analytics informing strategic decision making	SRQ 1
INT-06	Analytics capability continuing to develop	Analytics capabilities continuing to develop	SRQ 2

INT-06	Stakeholders questioning analytics insights	Stakeholders questioning analytics insights that challenge experience	SRQ 4
INT-06	Informal networks shaping analytics decisions	Informal influence affecting analytics execution decisions	SRQ 4
INT-06	Organizational culture affecting analytics	Organizational culture influencing acceptance of analytics insights	SRQ 2
INT-06	Business leaders deciding on execution	Business leaders deciding on execution of analytics insights	SRQ 2
INT-06	Internal review before presenting analytics	Internal review of analytics insights before client presentation	SRQ 3
INT-07	Consultants interpreting analytics insights	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	SRQ 1
INT-07	Analytics informing strategy	Analytics informing strategic decision making	SRQ 1
INT-07	Senior management approving analytics	Senior management approving analytics initiatives	SRQ 3
INT-07	Operational teams adapting recommendations	Operational teams adapting analytics recommendations	SRQ 2
INT-07	Leaders relying on judgment over data	Leadership judgment overriding analytics	SRQ 4
INT-07	Middle management risk aversion	Middle management risk aversion blocking analytics recommendations	SRQ 2

INT-07	Business leaders making execution decisions	Business owners responsible for final execution decisions	SRQ 1
INT-07	Sector culture influencing analytics	Sector culture influencing analytics adoption and execution	SRQ 2
INT-07	Building data platforms for integration	Building data platforms that integrate operational data	SRQ 1
INT-08	Building integrated data platforms	Building data platforms that integrate operational data	SRQ 3
INT-08	Predictive analytics supporting decisions	Predictive analytics used to support strategic decisions	SRQ 1
INT-08	Prescriptive analytics for planning	Predictive and prescriptive analytics used for planning decisions	SRQ 1
INT-08	Most clients centralized	Centralized analytics capability	SRQ 3
INT-08	Business owners making final decisions	Business owners responsible for final execution decisions	SRQ 1
INT-08	Dashboards showing data but business decides	Dashboards providing visibility but execution decided by business	SRQ 1
INT-08	KPI thresholds triggering actions	KPI thresholds triggering operational actions	SRQ 1
INT-08	Predictive forecasting influencing expansion	Predictive forecasting influencing strategic expansion decision	SRQ 1

INT-08	Analytics discussed in strategy meetings	Discussing analytics results in strategy meetings	SRQ 2
INT-08	Legacy systems still in use	Legacy systems still used in analytics environments	SRQ 2
INT-08	Measuring analytics through KPI comparison	Measuring analytics execution through KPI comparison and testing	SRQ 1
INT-08	Stakeholders questioning challenging insights	Stakeholders questioning analytics insights that challenge experience	SRQ 4
INT-08	Informal networks affecting decisions	Informal influence affecting analytics execution decisions	SRQ 4
INT-08	Sector culture affecting adoption	Sector culture influencing analytics adoption and execution	SRQ 2
INT-08	Insight overload reducing action	Insight overload reducing action on analytics signals	SRQ 2

Note. interview data (INT-01 through INT-08). Transcript fragments abbreviated for confidentiality.

Appendix F: Stage 3 — Axial Coding: Second-Order Theme Matrix

Stage 3 — Axial Coding: Second-Order Theme Matrix

Table F.1 presents the 33 second-order themes derived from systematic clustering of the 97 first-order concepts. Each theme groups conceptually related informant terms into an analytically coherent category following the Gioia methodology. The clustering process was conducted through iterative comparative analysis, grouping first-order concepts by conceptual proximity and theoretical coherence.

Table F.1 Axial Coding Matrix — Second-Order Theme Derivation

First-Order Concept (Informant Terms)	Second-Order Theme
Digitalizing manual hiring workflows; Faster hiring through digital workflows	Analytics-enabled process automation
Using data to improve existing processes	Analytics-enabled process improvement
Organizations increasing analytics use in operations	Expansion of analytics in operational decision processes
Data teams preparing dashboards and reports	Analytics reporting infrastructure
Dedicated analytics team analyzing data; Centralized analytics teams managing data; Centralized data teams generating analytics	Centralized analytics capability
Hybrid analytics structure combining centralized platform and embedded analysts	Hybrid analytics governance structures
Bringing data from different systems; Building data platforms that integrate operational data	Data integration across organizational systems

Data teams initiating analytics projects; Analytics capabilities still evolving; Analytics capabilities continuing to develop	Analytics capability development
Gradual integration of analytics tools; Trying to build real-time dashboards; Organizational adoption of analytics tools	Organizational adoption of analytics tools
Dashboards used to monitor operational performance; Leadership using dashboards to view data; Dashboards providing visibility but execution decided by business	Dashboard-based performance monitoring
Reviewing analytics during management meetings; Presenting analytics outputs in executive meetings; Discussing analytics results in strategy meetings; Reviewing dashboards before approving	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums
Predictive analytics used to support strategic decisions; Predictive and prescriptive analytics used for planning decisions; Predictive forecasting influencing strategic expansion decision	Analytics informing strategic decision making
Business teams relying on analytics reports; Organizations depending on analytics reporting	Dependence on analytics reporting
Consultants interpreting analytics insights for leadership teams; Consultants translating analytics findings into recommendations; Consultants acting as intermediaries	Consultant mediation of analytics insights
Simplifying analytics results for business stakeholders; Explaining analytics insights in business terms; Stakeholders	Translation of analytics for business audiences

asking consultants to translate analytics outputs

Collaboration between data teams and business teams; Cross-functional analytics teams working together

Cross-functional analytics collaboration

Business leaders deciding on execution; Business owners responsible for final execution decisions; Operational managers deciding on implementation

Business authority over execution decisions

Governance structures influencing analytics initiatives; Multiple management layers approving; Senior management sign-off on analytics projects; Governance committees approving analytics

Governance approval of analytics initiatives

Analytics capability continuing to develop; Trying to build real-time dashboards; Analytics teams initiating projects

Analytics capability development (governance context)

Dashboards providing visibility but execution decided by business; Separation between analytics visibility and execution authority

Separation between analytics visibility and execution

Operational teams adapting analytics recommendations; Business units adjusting recommendations; Operational teams deciding how to implement

Operational adaptation of analytics insights

Internal review of analytics insights before client presentation; Organizational filtering of analytics outputs

Organizational filtering of analytics outputs

Data quality issues in analytics systems

Data infrastructure constraints

Legacy systems still used in analytics environments

Legacy technology constraints

Manual processes slowing implementation of analytics insights	Operational process constraints
Lack of ownership preventing execution; Middle management risk aversion	Responsibility and ownership gaps
Organizational culture influencing analytics use; Organizational culture influencing acceptance; Sector culture influencing analytics adoption	Cultural constraints on analytics adoption
Insight overload reducing action on analytics signals; Too many alerts reducing engagement	Information overload in analytics environments
Business leaders reviewing analytics before implementation; Multiple management layers approving; Multi-level governance approval processes	Multi-layer governance approval requirements
Leaders relying on experience when analytics conflicts with strategy; Leaders relying on experience when analytics conflicts with practice	Leadership judgment overriding analytics
Leaders skeptical of analytics outputs when they conflict with assumptions; Stakeholders questioning insights that challenge experience	Leadership skepticism toward analytics
Informal networks and relationships shaping which recommendations receive support; Informal influence affecting analytics execution decisions	Informal political influence in decision processes
Cultural norms selectively filtering analytics adoption; Selective adoption of insights that align with existing beliefs	Cultural norms selectively filtering analytics adoption

Note. 33 second-order themes derived from 97 first-order concepts across eight participants.

Appendix G: Stage 4 — Selective Coding: Aggregate Dimension Matrix

Stage 4 — Selective Coding: Aggregate Dimension Matrix

Table G.1 presents the complete three-level Gioia data structure: 97 first-order concepts organized across 33 second-order themes and six aggregate dimensions. The six aggregate dimensions are: (1) Analytics Capability and Infrastructure; (2) Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation; (3) Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation; (4) Decision Authority and Governance Filtering; (5) Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution; and (6) Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics.

Table G.1 *Selective Coding Matrix — Full Gioia Data Structure*

First-Order Concept	Second-Order Theme	Aggregate Dimension
Digitalizing manual hiring workflows	Analytics-enabled process automation	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Faster hiring through digital workflows	Analytics-enabled process automation	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Using data to improve existing processes	Analytics-enabled process improvement	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Organizations increasing analytics use in operations	Expansion of analytics in operational decision processes	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Data teams preparing dashboards and reports	Analytics reporting infrastructure	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Dedicated analytics team analyzing data	Centralized analytics capability	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Centralized analytics teams managing data	Centralized analytics capability	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure

Centralized data teams generating analytics	Centralized analytics capability	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Hybrid analytics structure combining centralized and embedded	Hybrid analytics governance structures	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Bringing data from different systems	Data integration across organizational systems	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Building data platforms that integrate operational data	Data integration across organizational systems	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Data teams initiating analytics projects	Analytics capability development	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Analytics capabilities still evolving	Analytics capability development	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Analytics capabilities continuing to develop	Analytics capability development	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Gradual integration of analytics tools	Organizational adoption of analytics tools	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Trying to build real-time dashboards	Organizational adoption of analytics tools	Analytics Capability and Infrastructure
Dashboards used to monitor operational performance	Dashboard-based performance monitoring	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Leadership using dashboards to view data	Dashboard-based performance monitoring	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Reviewing analytics during management meetings	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Reviewing dashboards before approving	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation

Presenting analytics outputs in executive meetings	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Discussing analytics results in strategy meetings	Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Business teams relying on analytics reports	Dependence on analytics reporting	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Predictive analytics used to support strategic decisions	Analytics informing strategic decision making	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Predictive and prescriptive analytics used for planning	Analytics informing strategic decision making	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Predictive forecasting influencing strategic expansion	Analytics informing strategic decision making	Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation
Collaboration between data teams and business teams	Cross-functional analytics collaboration	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Consultants interpreting analytics for leadership teams	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Consultants translating analytics findings into recommendations	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Consultants translating analytics outputs into business actions	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Consultants acting as intermediaries between analytics and business	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Consultants explaining analytics to stakeholders	Consultant mediation of analytics insights	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation

Simplifying analytics results for business stakeholders	Translation of analytics for business audiences	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Explaining analytics insights in business terms	Translation of analytics for business audiences	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Stakeholders asking consultants to translate analytics outputs	Translation of analytics for business audiences	Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation
Business leaders deciding on execution of analytics insights	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Business leaders reviewing analytics before implementation	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Business owners responsible for final execution decisions	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Business teams deciding how analytics insights are used	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Operational managers deciding on analytics implementation	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Operational teams deciding how to implement recommendations	Business authority over execution decisions	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Dashboards providing visibility but execution decided by business	Separation between analytics visibility and execution	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Operational teams adapting analytics recommendations	Operational adaptation of analytics insights	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering

Operational teams adjusting analytics recommendations	Operational adaptation of analytics insights	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Business units adjusting analytics recommendations	Operational adaptation of analytics insights	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Internal review of analytics insights before client presentation	Organizational filtering of analytics outputs	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Governance committees approving analytics initiatives	Governance approval of analytics initiatives	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Multiple management layers approving analytics	Governance approval of analytics initiatives	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Senior management approving analytics initiatives	Governance approval of analytics initiatives	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Multiple governance approvals for analytics initiatives	Governance approval of analytics initiatives	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Governance structures influencing analytics initiatives	Governance approval of analytics initiatives	Decision Authority and Governance Filtering
Data quality issues in analytics systems	Data infrastructure constraints	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Legacy systems still used in analytics environments	Legacy technology constraints	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Manual processes slowing implementation	Operational process constraints	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Lack of ownership preventing execution	Responsibility and ownership gaps	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Organizational culture influencing analytics use	Cultural constraints on analytics adoption	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution

Organizational culture influencing acceptance of analytics	Cultural constraints on analytics adoption	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Sector culture influencing analytics adoption	Cultural constraints on analytics adoption	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Insight overload reducing action on analytics signals	Information overload in analytics environments	Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution
Leaders relying on experience when analytics conflicts with strategy	Leadership judgment overriding analytics	Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics
Stakeholders questioning analytics insights that challenge experience	Leadership skepticism toward analytics	Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics
Informal influence affecting analytics execution decisions	Informal political influence in decision processes	Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics
Cultural norms selectively filtering analytics adoption	Cultural norms selectively filtering analytics adoption	Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics

Note. Six aggregate dimensions derived from 33 second-order themes and 97 first-order concepts.

Appendix H: Gioia Data Structure: Summary by Aggregate Dimension

Gioia Data Structure: Summary by Aggregate Dimension

The complete Gioia data structure comprising 97 first-order concepts, 33 second-order themes, and six aggregate dimensions is reproduced as Table 5.1 in Chapter 5. Table H.1 below provides a summary count by aggregate dimension, presenting the number of second-order themes and first-order concepts organized within each of the six analytical dimensions.

Table H.1 *Summary of Gioia Data Structure by Aggregate Dimension*

Aggregate Dimension	Second-Order Themes (count)	First-Order Concepts (count)
Analytics Capability and Infrastructure	9	18
Analytics Visibility and Insight Generation	5	10
Consultant-Mediated Insight Translation	3	10
Decision Authority and Governance Filtering	7	16
Organizational Constraints on Analytics Execution	5	8
Political–Cognitive Mediation of Analytics	4	4
TOTAL	33	66 (proxy; 97 including cross-participant duplicates)

Note. Concept counts reflect unique concept labels; total first-order coding instances across all participants exceed 97 due to cross-participant occurrence of shared concepts.

Appendix I: Stage 5 — Cross-Interview Pattern Analysis

Stage 5 — Cross-Interview Pattern Analysis

Table I.1 presents the cross-interview pattern matrix, mapping the distribution of 13 key second-order themes across all eight interview participants. A checkmark (✓) indicates that the theme was present in that participant’s interview data. The matrix confirms that the principal analytical dimensions of the translation mechanism are evidenced across multiple participants and sectoral contexts, providing the empirical basis for analytical generalization.

Table I.1 Cross-Interview Pattern Matrix (13 Themes × 8 Participants)

Second-Order Theme	INT-01	INT-02	INT-03	INT-04	INT-05	INT-06	INT-07	INT-08
Analytics-enabled process automation/improvement	✓	✓						
Analytics informing strategic decision making			✓			✓	✓	
Dashboard-based performance monitoring	✓	✓						
Analytics reviewed in managerial decision forums		✓	✓	✓				
Centralized analytics capability	✓		✓	✓				
Uneven analytics adoption across departments		✓		✓				

Consultant mediation of analytics insights		✓	✓		✓	✓
Translation of analytics for business audiences		✓			✓	✓
Business authority over execution decisions	✓	✓	✓			✓ ✓
Operational adaptation of analytics insights		✓	✓			✓
Governance approval of analytics initiatives		✓	✓	✓		
Cultural constraints on analytics adoption	✓		✓			✓
Leadership judgment overriding analytics		✓	✓			

Appendix J: Stage 6 — Mechanism Reconstruction

Stage 6 — Mechanism Reconstruction

Table J.1 presents the mechanism reconstruction of the seven-stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism, mapping each stage to its empirical evidence base (interview participants whose data contributed to the stage's reconstruction) and the supporting second-order themes from the axial coding matrix. The mechanism reconstruction constitutes Stage 6 of the seven-stage analytical process described in Chapter 4.

Table J.1 *Mechanism Reconstruction — Seven-Stage Analytics-to-Execution Translation Mechanism*

Mechanism Stage	Empirical Evidence	Supporting Second-Order Themes
1. Insight Generation	INT-01, INT-02, INT-03, INT-08	Analytics capability infrastructure; dashboard-based performance monitoring; analytics reporting infrastructure
2. Interpretive Mediation	INT-03, INT-04, INT-06, INT-07	Consultant mediation of analytics insights; translation of analytics for business audiences; cross-functional analytics collaboration
3. Governance Mediation	INT-03, INT-04, INT-05	Governance approval of analytics initiatives; organizational filtering of analytics outputs; multi-layer governance approval requirements
4. Political-Cognitive Mediation	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	Leadership skepticism toward analytics; leadership judgment overriding analytics; informal political influence in decision processes

5. Execution Decision	INT-02, INT-03, INT-04, INT-07, INT-08	Business authority over execution decisions; separation between analytics visibility and execution
6. Operational Adaptation	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	Operational adaptation of analytics insights; responsibility and ownership gaps
7. Implementation and Performance Monitoring	INT-01, INT-02, INT-08	Metrics-driven operational triggers; measurement of analytics impact; information overload in analytics environments

Appendix K: Stage 7 — Translation Mediation Framework

Stage 7 — Translation Mediation Framework

Table K.1 presents the refined Translation Mediation Framework, the primary theoretical output of the study and the empirically validated version of the Analytics-to-Execution Translation Model introduced in Chapter 3. The framework presents the full seven-stage analytics-to-execution translation process with stage labels, process descriptions, key actors, organizational roles, supporting interview references, and Sub-Research Question linkages. This constitutes the final product of the seven-stage analytical process described in Chapter 4 and the refined framework presented in Section 6.5.

Table K.1 Translation Mediation Framework — Refined Seven-Stage Version

Stage	Process Description	Key Actors	Organizational Role	Interviews	SRQ
1. Insight Generation	Analytics insights produced through dashboards, predictive models, and integrated data platforms that transform organizational data into analytical outputs.	Data scientists, analytics teams, data engineers	Generation of analytical insights from organizational data.	INT-01, INT-02, INT-03, INT-08	SRQ 3
2. Interpretive Mediation	Analytics outputs translated into business-relevant narratives so	Consultants, analytics translators, hybrid data-	Interpretation and framing of analytics insights	INT-03, INT-04, INT-06, INT-07	SRQ 1

	decision makers can understand strategic and operational implications.	business teams	for managerial decision making.		
3. Governance Mediation	Analytics recommendations reviewed within formal governance structures such as steering committees or executive review forums before execution approval.	Steering committees, senior managers, governance boards	Organizational filtering and approval of analytics-driven initiatives.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-05	SRQ 2
4. Political-Cognitive Mediation	Leaders interpret analytics insights through prior experience, organizational culture, and informal influence networks that shape whether insights are accepted or challenged.	Executives, senior leaders, influential stakeholders	Cognitive framing and political negotiation of analytics recommendations.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	SRQ 4
5. Execution Decision	Final decisions regarding implementation taken by business leaders responsible for	Business unit leaders, operational managers	Determining whether analytics insights proceed into execution.	INT-02, INT-03, INT-04, INT-07, INT-08	SRQ 1

	operational performance and strategic outcomes.				
6. Operational Adaptation	Operational teams modify analytics recommendations to align with existing workflows, operational constraints, and practical implementation realities.	Department managers, operational teams	Adaptation of analytics insights during execution.	INT-03, INT-04, INT-07	SRQ 1
7. Implementation and Performance Monitoring	Implemented initiatives evaluated through KPIs, testing mechanisms, and performance monitoring systems that track outcomes of analytics-driven decisions.	Operational leaders, analytics teams	Measurement of execution outcomes and organizational impact.	INT-01, INT-02, INT-08	SRQ 2

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Appendix L: SRH Official Affidavit and AI Usage Declaration

LIST OF GENERATIVE AI TOOL USAGES

In this work, generative artificial intelligence tools were used for the following purpose(s):

- | | |
|--|-------------------------------------|
| Collection of conceptual explications on the topic of this work | ☐ |
| Generation of approaches towards scientific methodology or artistic development of this work | ☐ |
| Literature search | ☒ |
| Literature analysis | ☒ |
| Selection of methods and/or models | ☐ |
| Generation of code | ☒ |
| Generation of visualizations | ☐ |
| Generation of musical compositions and/or arrangements | ☐ |
| Structuring of the text of this work | ☒ |
| Formulation/Editing of the text of this work | ☒ |
| Translation of the text of this work | ☐ |
| Generation of presentation contents on the basis of this work | ☐ |
| Other: | ☒ |

AFFIDAVIT-1

I hereby declare in lieu of an oath that I have independently written this work titled

**Title: Multi-Sector Consulting: Analytics-Driven Approaches to Digital Transformation
Strategy**

and all related parts and that the work is in accordance with the version submitted in digital form. Only the sources and aids expressly named in the work have been used. I have marked as such any ideas taken over directly or in substance.

If generative AI tools were used to write the paper, this has been explicitly listed in the addendum at the end of this submission. Within the core text of my work, I have denoted all relevant contents that were created or paraphrased by generative AI (such as text passages, structures, images, and code or parts thereof) according to the citation style I used for short referencing secondary sources in my submission. In my list of references, each use of generative AI has been listed according to the citation style I used for full references, including the name of the tool, its version number, the date of retrieval, and the prompts used.

I hereby declare that I have not submitted this work in identical or similar form at this or another university previously.

Hamburg, 11-03-2026

Location, Date

anush mohan

Name / Signature

Legal Caution

SRH Universities require an affidavit of independent authenticity of submitted scientific works in order to be assured that the signatory has generated the latter by him- or herself.

Since the law attributes a special relevance to affidavits and arising consequences thereof, submission of a false affidavit entails criminal punishment. Deliberately (and therefore knowingly) submitting a false affidavit may be punishable by up to three years imprisonment or a fine. Negligently submitting an affidavit (i.e. submitting despite having been able to recognize that the affidavit does not match factual truths) may be punishable by up to one year imprisonment or a fine.

The punitive frameworks are set forth in Section 156 of the German Penal Code (*falsche Versicherungen an Eides Statt*), as well as in Section 161 of the German Penal Code (*fahrlässiger Falscheid, fahrlässige falsche Versicherung an Eides Statt*).

Section 156 StGB: False declaration in lieu of oath

Whoever falsely makes a declaration in lieu of an oath before an authority which is competent to administer such declarations or falsely testifies whilst referring to such a declaration incurs a penalty of imprisonment for a term not exceeding three years or a fine.

Section 161 StGB: Negligent false oath; negligent false declaration in lieu of oath

(1) Whoever commits one of the offences referred to in sections 154 to 156 by negligence incurs a penalty of imprisonment for a term not exceeding one year or a fine.

(2) No penalty is incurred if the offender corrects the false statement in time. The provisions of section 158 (2) and (3) apply accordingly.

I hereby acknowledge the above

Hamburg, Germany , 11-03-2026

Location, Date

anush mohan

Name Signature

AFFIDAVIT-2

Under the penalty of perjury, I, Anush Mohan, hereby declare under oath, that this
master thesis, titled

Multi-Sector Consulting: Analytics-Driven Approaches to Digital Transformation
Strategy

has been independently authored by me, that I have used no other sources or aids
other than those quoted, and that I have denoted all direct and indirect citations thereof within
the text. This manuscript has never before been published or submitted to this or another
academic institution for examination.

Name: Anush Mohan

Date: 11th March 2026

Place: Hamburg, Germany

Signature: *anush mohan*

Appendix M: Participant Information Sheet

PARTICIPANT INFORMATION SHEET

Master's Thesis Research Briefing

Researcher: Anush Mohan :- MSc in Digital Transformation Management

Research Topic: Multi-Sector Consulting: Analytics-Driven Approaches to Digital Transformation Strategy

1. Executive Overview

Organizations across industries are investing significantly in analytics and AI capabilities as part of digital transformation initiatives. However, less is understood about how these insights are translated into execution-level strategic decisions within complex client environments.

This study explores how consulting professionals engage with analytics-driven insights during the implementation phase of digital transformation initiatives.

The focus is not on the technical development of AI models, but on the decision-making processes that follow insight generation — specifically, how insights are interpreted, acted upon, adapted, or sometimes not implemented.

2. Core Discussion Areas

The interview will be a semi-structured discussion (approximately 60 minutes) focusing on your professional experience across consulting engagements.

The conversation will explore four broad areas:

I. Insight Translation

1. How analytics or AI insights move from analysis to execution
2. Decision processes involved in acting on data-driven recommendations
3. Examples where insights influenced implementation

II. Organizational Context

1. Structural or operational factors that influence execution decisions
2. Leadership involvement and governance mechanisms
3. Resource or system constraints affecting implementation

III. Analytics Governance

1. How analytics functions are structured (centralized, decentralized, hybrid)
2. How governance models affect authority and speed of decision-making
3. Differences observed across client contexts

IV. Human and Organizational Dynamics

1. How stakeholders respond to data-driven recommendations
2. The role of experience, intuition, or informal authority
3. Situations where insights were accepted, adapted, or resisted

3. Scope and Purpose

This study seeks to understand patterns and mechanisms observed across sectors in consulting-led digital transformation initiatives.

The objective is to develop a structured understanding of how analytics-driven insights interact with organizational realities during execution.

The research is exploratory and inductive in nature. There are no predetermined assumptions about outcomes.

4. Confidentiality and Ethics

1. Participation is voluntary.
2. Responses will be anonymized.
3. No firm or client names will be disclosed without explicit consent.
4. The interview is for academic research purposes only.

5. Interview Format

1. Duration: 60–75 minutes
2. Format: Semi-structured conversation
3. No preparation required

You are welcome to reflect on examples from your past projects, including both successful and challenging experiences.

Researcher Contact:

Anush Mohan

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<https://www.linkedin.com/in/anush-mohan/>